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BJP wins Falta seat by more than 1 lakh votes
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NEARBY



‘Decision on AIADMK split will prove neutrality’

CHENNAI
Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar has said that everyone would know whether or not he had functioned in an impartial manner in the issue of split in the AIADMK Legislature Party when he took a decision and announced it in the Assembly. » **PAGE 2**

Former MP P. Venugopal quits AIADMK

CHENNAI
Former MP P. Venugopal, who was elected to the Lok Sabha twice from Tiruvallur constituency, quit the AIADMK on Sunday. He held key positions in the medical wing of the party since its inception and had also served as its Parliamentary Party leader in the Lok Sabha. » **PAGE 2**

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Rubio, Jaishankar stress need for ‘unimpeded’ maritime trade

‘Tactical’ relations the U.S. has with other countries will not come at the ‘expense’ of strategic alliance with India, says U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio; Trump speaks over the phone at an event, says India can 100% count on the U.S. President

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The United States works with many countries at a “tactical” level, but those relations will not disturb the strategic partnership with India, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said here on Sunday.

Addressing a joint press conference at the Hyderabad House lawns, Mr. Rubio said the idea of a “free and open Indo-Pacific” went beyond the Indo-Pacific to other “international waters” and accused Iran of blocking the Strait of Hormuz while sponsoring proxy terror groups.

Speaking on the occasion, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar acknowledged the disruption to supply chains because of the U.S.-Israel war on Iran, and said that both India and the U.S. had “very strong interest” to ensure “safe and unimpeded maritime commerce”.

“As far as our relations with other countries, yeah, we have relations and we work at the tactical level, for example, and in many other ways with countries all over the world. So does India. That’s what respon-



Pivotal talks: External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar and U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio address the press at Hyderabad House in New Delhi after their meeting on Sunday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

sible nation states do but I don’t view our relation with any country in the world as coming at the expense of our strategic alliance with India...,” Mr. Rubio said. He was responding to a question on the Pakistan-U.S. ties that are being discussed worldwide because of the prominent role that Pakistan has been playing in bringing the conflict in the Gulf to a pause.

Mr. Rubio, who arrived in India for a four-day visit on Saturday, held a day-long meeting with Mr.

Jaishankar and other officials of the Indian side including Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, in which energy, bilateral trade, and visa issues for skilled Indian workers were among the items discussed.

Trump speaks

Later on Sunday night, U.S. President Donald Trump called Prime Minister Narendra Modi a “great friend” and said India can “count on me 100%”. In a telephone call with U.S. Ambassador Sergio Gor, which was played out loud

during an event at the Bharat Mandapam celebrating 250 years of U.S. independence, where both Mr. Jaishankar and Mr. Rubio were present, Mr. Trump said the U.S. was closer to India than ever. “I love the Prime Minister.. I am a big fan [of Mr. Modi]... we have never been closer to India and India can count on me 100% and our country. If they [India] ever need help, they know where to call,” Mr. Trump said.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 8**

Congress targets Modi over Rubio’s trade claim

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Targeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi over U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio’s statement that India has committed to purchasing \$500 billion worth of American goods over the next five years, the Congress on Sunday alleged that the “compromised PM” was going the extra mile to appease his “good friend”.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh questioned why key announcements relating to India’s foreign policy and bilateral engagements were emanating from Washington rather than New Delhi. Noting that India’s annual imports from the U.S. stood at \$52.9 billion, he said this would have to be doubled to honour the commitment claimed by Mr. Rubio.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 8**

Quad grouping is ‘vital’, says Japan’s Foreign Minister

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Responding to concerns that the Quad has lost its relevance, Japanese Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi has said that the four-nation grouping remains a “vital framework”. In a written interview with *The Hindu* ahead of the Quadrilateral Foreign Ministers’ Meeting in New Delhi on Tuesday, Mr. Motegi indicated that “cooperation over critical minerals” needed for green energy and high technology would be at the top of the meeting agenda.

Japan is working on critical minerals’ projects in India, he said while calling for improved infrastructure, more tax subsidies, and protection for intellectual property rights.

The Quad meeting, which will see External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar host Mr. Motegi, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio, and Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong, is expected to take stock of the conflict in West Asia, the Strait of Hormuz blockade, and U.S. President Donald Trump’s visit this month to China. It will also set the agenda for the Quad Summit that has not taken place since 2024 amid In-



Toshimitsu Motegi

dia-U.S. tensions on a number of issues.

“The Quad remains a vital framework among countries that share fundamental values and strategic interests. It has delivered concrete results across a wide range of areas, including maritime security, economic security, and cybersecurity,” Mr. Motegi said, but side-stepped queries on why the mechanism finds little mention in strategy documents of member countries.

He declined to respond to a specific question on whether the U.S.’s torpedoing of the Iranian ship *IRIS Dena* in the Indian Ocean on March 4 would be raised by fellow Quad members, given their agenda of ensuring peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific region.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 8**

Suicide bombing attack near railway track kills at least 24 in Pakistan’s Baloch province

Associated Press
QUETTA

At least 24 people were killed and over 70 wounded in Pakistan’s Balochistan province on Sunday when a suicide bomber detonated an explosives-laden vehicle near a railway track as a passenger train passed through Quetta, the provincial capital, officials said.

The outlawed Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) later claimed responsibility for the attack in a statement sent to journalists. The militant group, which demands independence from Pakistan’s central government, said it targeted a train carrying security personnel.

The attack, in an area usually having security forces present, badly damaged several nearby buildings and smashed more than a dozen vehicles parked along the road, according to eyewitnesses. Footage shared online showed two of the train coaches overturn from the force of the explosion and catch fire, sending thick black smoke into the air.

Doctors at local hospitals said more than 20 people were under treatment in critical condition. Pakistan’s President Asif



Security personnel and local people carry out rescue efforts at the site of the explosion in Quetta, Pakistan, on Sunday. AP

Ali Zardari, who denounced the bombing, said militants and their backers sought to undermine Pakistan’s role in regional and international peace efforts. He promised in a statement that his country “will defeat terrorists, their facilitators, financiers and those providing them safe havens.”

Strongly condemning the attack, Pakistan’s Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, in a post on X, called it a “cowardly act of terrorism” and offered condolences to the families of the victims.

Balochistan Chief Minister Sarfraz Bugti said the militants targeted “innocent civilians, including women and children,” and vowed to “hunt [those responsible down]”.

A medical emergency has been declared at hospitals in Quetta following the explosion, and an investigation has been launched, Balochistan provincial government spokesperson Shahid Rind said.

Restive region

The oil- and mineral-rich region in southwestern Pakistan has long been the scene of a low-level insurgency with security forces, government installations, and civilians in the province and elsewhere in the country being frequently targeted.

In November 2024, at least 26 people, security personnel among them, were killed in a similar attack on a train station in Quetta, which was also claimed by the BLA.

I wasn’t allowed to see her body, mother of murdered girl alleges

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE/SALEM

The mother of the 10-year-old girl, who was sexually assaulted and murdered near Coimbatore, alleged on Sunday that her husband took the child’s body to his native place in Salem and cremated it without her consent or allowing her to see the mortal remains.

The woman, who spoke to mediapersons in Coimbatore in the evening, said she decided not to accept her daughter’s body until “justice is served”. However, it was released from the morgue in Coimbatore after her husband’s signature was obtained, she said.

Police action sought

“They did not show me the body and left ESI Hospital premises through the back gate. Though we tried to follow the ambulance to have a glimpse of the body, they left the spot. Though I went to his native place in Salem, they cremated the body without even showing me her face,” she alleged, demanding police action against her husband and relatives. Responding to social media posts and allegations that she was under the influence of alcohol and was unconscious when the main accused, K.

Karthi, 33, abducted her daughter from the neighbourhood at Pallapalayam near Sulur on the evening of May 21, the woman said she had consumed a soft drink that her husband had kept in the fridge. She suspected that alcohol was mixed in it.

“I drank the cold drink from the fridge... I lost consciousness after consuming it,” said the woman, adding that no one should spread slander against her in her current situation.

The woman also denied any acquaintance with Karthi as alleged by certain people on social media. She said she came to know of him only after his arrest, and no one allowed her to explain her side.

Karthi, who allegedly suffered fractures on the right arm and leg while attempting to escape from the police, was shifted to the prisoners’ ward from the intensive care unit of a hospital.

Relief handed over

Earlier, Minister for Transport A. Vijay Tamilan Parthiban and Minister for Backward Classes Welfare V. Sampath Kumar visited the girl’s native place in Mettur taluk of Salem district and handed over a relief assistance of ₹7 lakh to the family.

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Residents’ welfare associations raise concern over local body governance

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Alliance of Resident Welfare Associations (T.N. AORWA) has urged Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay to avoid conducting local body elections in the State and strengthen direct administrative governance for efficient public administration.

In a representation submitted to the Chief Minister, the federation said elections to Corporations, Municipalities, Town Panchayats, and Panchayat Unions were traditionally conducted within six months after Assembly elections.

However, it said the present situation required re-consideration in the larger public interest.

The federation alleged that during the previous regime, several local body representatives were corrupt, and misuse of power was their primary objective. It claimed that RWAs and social activists who raised civic issues and public grievances faced inti-

The associations urge the govt. to avoid conducting local body elections

midation, threats, and interference. According to the federation, government officials were also prevented from functioning independently because of political pressure and interference from local representatives. It said such practices weakened local administration and created fear among the public.

The T.N. AORWA said people had placed their trust in the present TVK government, expecting transparent and corruption-free regime. It expressed apprehension that the existing system could lead to a continuation of corruption and misuse of authority if local body elections were conducted again.

The federation also referred to former Chief Minister Jayalalithaa postponing local body elections in 2016 citing governance and public welfare concerns.

Metro work damages road near Indira Nagar station site

Residents say the road space has drastically shrunk due to the station construction work and road condition has worsened; CMRL officials say that the matter has been taken up with the contractor

CITY MATTERS

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

For months now, the Chennai Metro Rail’s station construction work at Indira Nagar in Adyar for the phase II project has left the roads near the site damaged, causing inconvenience to the commuters and residents.

Chennai Metro Rail has been building stations in underground and elevated networks in many areas for the 118.9-km phase II project. As part of the corridor 3 construction from Madhavaram to SIPCOT via Adyar, Chennai Metro Rail has been carrying out station work near the Indira Nagar Water Tank.

For months now, the quality of the road in Indira Nagar Second Avenue and a small section of the Third Avenue near the signal has deteriorated making it an uncomfortable ride for commuters.

L.J. Singaravelan, president of Adyar Kasturba Na-



In poor shape: The quality of the road in Indira Nagar Second Avenue and a small section of the Third Avenue near the signal has deteriorated, making it an uncomfortable ride for commuters. R. RAGU

gar-South Residents’ Welfare Association says, commuters find it difficult to take right from First Avenue to the Second Avenue near the Indira Nagar Water Tank Signal. “The road space has drastically shrunk due to the station construction work, and the condition of the road has worsened significantly in the last few months,

making it difficult, particularly for the motorists,” he adds.

Krishnakumar, a resident of Indira Nagar, says he has to cross these two stretches either to travel to Velachery or Sardar Patel Road. “There should be some accountability. Shouldn’t they relay the road on periodic intervals when they know it is in a

poor shape due to their work? It is also tough for the residents to walk,” he said.

According to officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL), they have already informed the contractor regarding the problem. “We will relay the road around the site at the earliest,” an official said.

‘Govt. will take necessary steps to modernise prison administration’



Taking stock: Law Minister R. Nirmalkumar during an inspection at the Central Prison in Puzhal on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Minister for Law R. Nirmalkumar, on Sunday, said the modernisation of prison administration was the need of the hour and that the State government would take all necessary measures to gradually implement it, including the adoption of digital technologies.

Speaking to journalists after inspecting the Central

Prison at Puzhal near Chennai, the Minister said measures would be taken to simplify and strengthen the screening process for visitors through the adoption of digital technologies and ensure that no prohibited items, including narcotic substances, were smuggled into prisons.

He said an inspection was conducted to check the availability of equipment required for hospitals and other basic ameni-

ties such as drinking water supply required for 1,500 inmates lodged.

Many remand prisoners continue to remain in prison beyond the stipulated period, and the Law Department would explore the possibilities of extending legal aid to them, he said.

Mr. Nirmalkumar said inspections would be conducted in all the prisons in the State, and the requirements would be taken into consideration. Mr. Nirmal-

kumar also said that in both the Electricity and Prisons departments, instructions had been given to avoid unnecessary administrative transfers.

As per rules, routine transfers of officials who had worked for certain years in a particular position and punishment transfers with proper notes would continue, while unnecessary administrative transfers would be avoided, he added.

Timings
CHENNAI

MONDAY, MAY. 25		
RISE	05:43	SET 18:30
RISE	13:43	SET 01:23
TUESDAY, MAY. 26		
RISE	05:42	SET 18:30
RISE	14:30	SET 01:59
WEDNESDAY, MAY. 27		
RISE	05:42	SET 18:31
RISE	15:18	SET 02:35

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	41	26
Chennai Airport	41	30
Chennai City	39	29

Chennai Airport Today
35°C Day will be warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be uneasy. Chances of light rain and thundershower.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
36°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm and uneasy with moderate winds. Night will remain uneasy.

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Reptiles, rodents, and debris make life difficult for Kalakshetra Colony residents

R. Aishwaryaa
CHENNAI

Garbage strewn across the sand, mounds of debris along the shoreline, and rows of thatched huts vulnerable to flooding continue to mark portions of the beach stretch close to Kalakshetra Colony in Besant Nagar, and close to north of the Thiruvannmiyur Beach.

Residents alleged that civic issues and Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) violations remain undressed. “At night, sometimes we wake up to check whether snakes have entered our huts. There are no garbage bins here, so waste is dumped in the open. Reptiles, rats, and street dogs are common here,” said Sarasa and Dasamma, elderly fish vendors who have lived on the beach for several years.

They said, “Around five



Construction materials dumped on the stretch close to where fisherfolk park their boats, nearby Kalakshetra Colony. R. AISHWARYAA

families on the stretch live in huts with thatched roofs, asbestos-sheet walls and broken doors. People with means are building new cement houses. We cannot afford upgrading to concrete homes, so we moved to huts. There are no electricity or sewage connections for huts here, so we depend on public toilets for bathing and other needs.” Residents said debris had been dumped at two locations along the

coast to harden the sandy surface for easier movement of vehicles and transport of goods.

Cement bags, tiles, and construction materials were seen stacked at portions of the stretch, close to where fisherfolk park their boats, which leads towards the houses there. Attempts to lay roads close to the shoreline had earlier been halted by Chennai Corporation officials, residents said, adding that fresh ac-

tivity had resumed in recent weeks. Locals expressed concern that additional construction near the coast could increase risks during heavy rain, flooding, and sea ingress.

Under CRZ regulations, construction activity is restricted within 200 metres of the High Tide Line along ecologically-sensitive coastal stretches. Garbage and debris were also found dumped behind the Arupadai Veedu temple, residents said, and urged authorities to install surveillance cameras and prevent further dumping.

A GCC official of the Adyar Zone said a portion of the beach right behind the temple was cleared later on Saturday. The remaining will be taken up in the following days and steps for surveillance will also be taken up, said Velachery MLA R. Kumar.

They were admitted to the Tambaram Government Hospital. They were later transferred to the Institute of Child Health in Egmore, for advanced treatment.

The Chromepet Traffic Investigation Police have filed a case and are investigating.

Man killed as car falls into ditch from flyover near Kundrathur

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 44-year-old school teacher was killed after the car he was travelling fell into a ditch on the Vandalur - Ponneri Outer Ring Road (ORR) near Kundrathur on Sunday.

The Tambaram Police said Prabhakar, a resident of NGO Colony in Ponneri and worked as a teacher at a government school in Pulicat.

On Sunday, he was travelling in a car, which was being driven by his colleague Sasikala. Sasikala’s

daughter Dikshitha, 16, and three other students Lohith, 8, Magizhini, 8, and Mazhali, 4, were also travelling in the vehicle. They were heading towards Vandalur.

When the car was on the flyover near Kundrathur, Sasikala lost control of

the vehicle, and it fell into the ditch.

In the impact, Prabhakar died on the spot and Sasikala sustained minor injuries.

Four children injured
The four children sustained severe injuries.

INBRIEF



Over 440 students get jobs at Vaishnav College career fair

A total of 446 students received appointment letters at a job fair organised by Dwaraka Doss Goverdhan Doss Vaishnav College on Saturday. Salary packages ranged from ₹2 lakh to ₹6 lakh per annum. The event saw the participation of 710 students from the college - 520 UG and 190 PG students. S. Santhosh Baboo, principal of the institution, termed the job fair a “second opportunity” for graduates and urged students to treat employment as a learning phase, adding that experience would eventually lead to better pay. As many as 45 companies participated in the fair, offering full-time opportunities across sectors including healthcare, finance, teaching, marketing, and technology.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper. thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (May 25, Monday), the following articles are available:

■ What is China's Hainan FTP initiative? newsth.live/freetradeport

■ Long-awaited anti-COVID drug is also a milestone against future viruses newsth.live/anticoviddrug

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I, MRS.A. KALAVATHI , W/o. Late Mr.Selvam, 65 yrs, residing at Patner Kesu Road, S.Kodiar, Tirupattur, Jolarpet, Tamil Nadu-635 851, my Aadhaar Card No. 8236 5588 9507 & Indian bank Savings A/C No.620332464 as SELVAM my husband name has been mentioned in my Passport No.J2481515 as PANNEERSELVAM, I declare that the above said name SELVAM & PANNEERSELVAM both are same person	MY DAUGHTER , Kuzhali, daughter of Thiru Siva Kumar V, born on 4th June 2011 (District of Thirai: Thanjavur), residing at No. 4, Thalai Sundharam Nagar, Kundrathur, Chennai-600 069, shall henceforth be known as S. KUZHALI SHRI. SHENBAGAVALLI. S (Mother)
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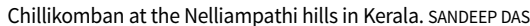
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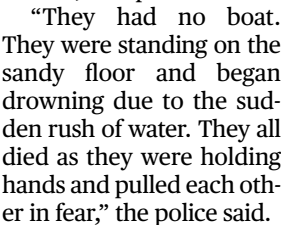


Though efforts were made to rescue the elephant using a backhoe, the elephant could not be lifted due to its weight and the current in the canal. It was

“There are no known reports of the elephant having attacked people in Nelliampathi. It loved jackfruit and mangoes,” he said.

The Chief Minister has also directed officials not to halt traffic for the movement of his convoy.

“They were not tourists but had likely entered the



Meanwhile, Prime Minister Narendra Modi too expressed grief over the loss of lives in the drowning incident and announced an ex gratia payment of ₹2 lakh each to the next of kin of the deceased persons.

But Congress leaders, including Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala and Electricity Minister Sunny Joseph, had strongly defended the appointment, describing Mr. Kelkar, a 2003-batch IAS officer, as an upright and efficient officer who has handled multiple portfolios.

Congress leaders also maintained that Mr. Kelkar's appointment cannot be equated with the development in West Bengal.

The delay in providing copies of answer sheets and processing revaluation requests is feared to affect students who apply for admissions in engineering and other courses.

TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	62	33	24	Kozhikode	70	31	25
Ahmedabad	—	42	29	Kurnool	42	35	26
Aizawl	—	27	13	Lucknow	—	42	25
Allahabad	—	44	29	Madurai	65	38	28
Angkor	66	22	22	Malanguru	75	31	26
Bhopal	—	38	26	Mumbai	—	36	30
Bhubaneswar	—	43	28	Mysuru	64	32	22
Chandigarh	—	43	26	New Delhi	—	43	32
Chennai	54	36	29	Patna	56	39	29
Coimbatore	55	33	24	Port Blair	66	33	27
Dehradun	—	41	24	Puducherry	—	38	27
Gangtok	75	24	14	Pune	51	37	25
Goa	78	30	27	Raipur	—	44	25
Guwahati	76	30	23	Ranchi	—	42	27
Hubbali	51	29	23	Shillong	51	26	18
Hyderabad	—	39	27	Siliguri	52	26	16
Imphal	51	29	20	Srinagar	65	26	26
Jaipur	—	41	29	Thiruvananthapuram	81	32	24
Kochi	67	33	25	Triruchi	—	38	27
Kohima	75	26	17	Vijayawada	48	25	25
Kolkata	—	37	28	Visakhapatnam	—	37	25

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)						
Pollutants in the air you are breathing						
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE
Ahmedabad	12	.73	33	36	101	Orange
Bangalore	..	..14	24	31	39	Green
Chennai	14	10	28	33	45	Green
Delhi	24	.66	34	157	265	Red
Hyderabad	10	20	20	60	90	Green
Kolkata	12	22	31	101	111	Orange
Lucknow	12	11	46	169	107	Orange
Mumbai	11	15	10	11	31	Green
Pune	..	..95	22	22	32	Green
Vishakhapatnam	19	50	13	58	145	Orange

Yesterday

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Charkhi Daddi, Haryana recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 336, indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala recorded a healthy AQI score of 18.

Air Quality Color: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulfur Dioxide: Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain valuable important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide: Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide: High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

“Many things are happening with respect to the SIR. That is why we are working to create awareness of it. The poor and common people need to be told what the SIR is. In many States, 50 to 90 lakh voters are being removed. The SIR is beginning in Karnataka as well,” Mr. Shivakumar told reporters before the conclave. “Once the voting right is lost, people will lose government benefits.”

Mr. Nagi Reddy accused the government of mishandling urea supply and failing to prevent black marketing.



Coerced consent

Supreme Court should set aside sedition as constitutionally unsustainable

The Indian state has not infrequently used the colonial offence of sedition, codified under Section 124A of the Indian Penal Code (IPC), as a tool to quell dissent. In May 2022, the Supreme Court of India asked State and central governments to refrain from registering new first information reports and from taking coercive measures under Section 124A in *S.G. Vombatkere vs Union of India* while the Centre said it would “reconsider” the provision. When the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) took effect in 2024, Parliament effectively replaced Section 124A with Section 152 and increased the minimum sentence to seven years. It was sedition by a new name. In February 2026, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant orally observed that the Centre’s promise in 2022 to review the provision could not bind Parliament. As if to release the pressure on courts, but also effectively easing the country’s passage into the BNS era, on May 21, 2026, the Court said that if an accused person has no objection, courts may proceed on cases involving Section 124A. However, such consent from the accused may be coerced, especially if they lack robust legal representation, because the alternative for the incarcerated persons is indefinite delay. It is effectively a Hobson’s choice between bad and worse outcomes.

Indeed, as the 2022 stay paused the use of Section 124A pending constitutional challenge, how meaningful an accused person’s consent to trial can be where refusal may entail prolonged delay is unclear. *S.G. Vombatkere* also provided those charged with sedition to move for bail, meaning liberty rather than restoring proceedings was the intended remedy for frozen trials. The May clarification swings in the other direction, and also stands in contrast to the ‘bail is the rule’ principle that the Court recently reinforced in *Syed Ifthikhar Andrabi*. If the Court wished to preserve agency, it should have paired continuation with a presumption of bail. The 2022 stay was also intended to annul the chilling effect of the charge of sedition on free speech. Now, wealthier or politically connected accused persons may secure bail through sustained litigation and wait out proceedings outside the prison, whereas poorer prisoners who are unable to secure bail will be compelled to consent to a trial, if only to obtain a verdict. As a result, liberty could depend on the capacity to litigate rather than on legal principles. Finally, if the state knows that cases involving constitutionally contested offences can remain in limbo while the accused persons are incarcerated, there is a perverse incentive for bad-faith state actors to not resolve the underlying uncertainty quickly. Instead of determining once and for all whether sedition as a criminal offence is constitutionally sustainable, the Court has passed the burden to the accused and declined to do its own duty.

Cash, clash, clay

The French Open starts amid a dispute over prize money

In the Open Era (from 1968), only six men have won each of the four tennis Majors at least once. Rod Laver achieved it in a single breathtaking year in 1969; Andre Agassi, Rafael Nadal, Roger Federer and Novak Djokovic toiled long and hard, ranging from five years to more than eight; Carlos Alcaraz completed it early this February in less than three years and five months. At the latest French Open, however, World No. 1 Jannik Sinner can shade all except Laver by being the quickest after the legendary Aussie – in under two years and five months since winning his first at the 2024 Australian Open. The stars have aligned well for Sinner to hoist the Coupe des Mousquetaires and banish the bad memories from 12 months ago when he missed three championship points versus Alcaraz. He is on an awe-inspiring streak of 29 match wins and has swept all three ATP Masters 1000 competitions on clay leading in. The 24-year-old’s generational rival Alcaraz – whom he met in three Slam finals in 2025 – is missing because of a wrist injury, and Alexander Zverev, the second seed, has lost his previous nine contests to the Italian. Djokovic, 39 and a record 24-time Major champion, is undercooked, having played just four times since his worthy runner-up finish at the Australian Open.

There is no such overwhelming favourite among women, with Aryna Sabalenka, Iga Swiatek, Coco Gauff and Elena Rybakina all fancied. World No. 1 Sabalenka, who lost a topsy-turvy summit clash to Gauff in 2025, has reached semifinals or better in 12 of her last 13 Slams. But she is without a final on clay this season, a first such occurrence since 2020. Swiatek is a four-time Roland-Garros titlist, and will look to reclaim her kingdom with some help from Francisco Roig, a coach who was once part of 14-time winner Nadal’s team. Gauff was a finalist in Rome recently, but has lifted just one trophy since her Paris success. Rybakina, champion in Melbourne, is capable, but dirt is her least-preferred surface. No. 7 Elina Svitolina is a contender, having overcome both Swiatek and Gauff in Rome for her biggest title after returning from a maternity break in April 2023. Mirra Andreeva, 19 and seeded eighth, boasts of two finals, a semifinal and a quarterfinal from her last four events. However, the setting for this high-quality fare is less than ideal, for players are miffed at the French Open organisers – and other Majors by extension – for denying a larger share of the tournament revenue as prize money. An amicable settlement that would help lower ranked youngsters is essential for the long-term health of the sport.

The United States’ decision to tighten restrictions again on Russian seaborne oil may seem like another chapter in the sanctions battle over the Ukraine war. But beneath the headlines lies a much larger story – one that directly affects India and much of the developing world.

The issue is no longer just Russia. It is whether the global energy system can withstand simultaneous geopolitical shocks without causing prolonged inflation, supply insecurity and economic instability across Asia. For over three years, the world has attempted an unprecedented balancing act: keeping one of the largest oil exporters under heavy sanctions while trying to maintain stable energy prices. That balancing act is becoming increasingly fragile. The latest restrictions come at a sensitive moment. Oil markets are already unsettled by conflict in West Asia, persistent disruptions in maritime trade routes and growing concerns over the Strait of Hormuz, the world’s most critical oil transit chokepoint. In such conditions, even policy signals from Washington can alter freight rates, insurance premiums and crude price expectations almost overnight.

Why India cannot ignore this development India imports nearly 90% of its crude oil and is the world’s third-largest importer as well as one of the fastest-growing energy consumers. Unlike many developed economies, where energy demand has plateaued, India’s energy needs will keep rising with industrialisation, urbanisation and expanding mobility. It is this reality that shapes India’s energy choices.

When Russian crude began flowing into India in large volumes after 2022, many in the West viewed it through a geopolitical lens. India saw it



Shrikant Madhav Vaidya
Former Chairman of IndianOil Corporation Ltd. and an energy strategist

The world’s emerging economies are increasingly being caught between geopolitics and energy survival

How energy shocks travel into India’s economy

The implications for India extend far beyond crude prices alone. Modern energy disruptions now transmit through multiple interconnected channels

Energy shock	Immediate impact	Secondary impact on India
Higher crude oil prices	Costlier imports	Inflation and rupee pressure
Strait of Hormuz disruption	Supply uncertainty	LPG and fuel logistics stress
Shipping insurance surge	Higher landed crude cost	Refining margin pressure
Russian crude restrictions	Reduced supply flexibility	Higher sourcing costs
Freight disruptions	Delayed cargoes	Inventory and stock management strain

Sources: IEA, Energy Institute Statistical Review, industry and shipping estimates

India’s green transition still runs on coal

The recent rise in global energy prices following the escalation of the conflict in West Asia has once again exposed India’s continuing vulnerability to external energy shocks. Despite years of policy emphasis on renewable energy, nearly half of India’s fossil fuel imports still transit through the Strait of Hormuz, including crude shipments from Saudi Arabia and Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) imports from Qatar.

This vulnerability sits uneasily alongside the dominant narrative around India’s clean energy transition. Over the past decade, India has emerged as one of the world’s fastest-growing renewable energy markets. Since 2017, renewables have consistently accounted for the largest share of new power capacity additions in the country. In numbers, renewable energy sources accounted for 42.4% of India’s installed power capacity by March 2026, up dramatically from just 0.72% in March 2005. Over the same period, coal’s share in installed capacity fell from 58.7% to 42.2%.

By conventional metrics, India appears well into an energy transition. Yet, the persistence of energy price shocks reveals a more complicated reality. Installed capacity is not the same as actual electricity generation. While renewables now account for over two-fifths of installed capacity, they generated only 15.8% of electricity in April 2026. Coal, by contrast, still accounted for 71.8% of electricity generation, only marginally lower than its 76.2% share in March 2019.

Capacity and generation gap

This gap between capacity and generation is central to understanding India’s energy system. The country has succeeded in building renewable infrastructure, but not yet in replacing coal in the actual electricity mix. In effect, renewable energy is being added on top of coal rather than



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Rising renewable capacity has yet to substantially displace coal generation

as an economic stabiliser during a period of extreme volatility. Russian oil helped moderate inflationary pressures, improved refinery economics and reduced dependence on any single region. It provided supply flexibility at a time of great turbulence in global energy markets. Critics often frame the debate as morality versus commerce. But energy-importing countries rarely have that luxury.

For countries such as India, energy affordability directly affects transport costs, food inflation, fertilizer subsidies, manufacturing competitiveness and household spending. A sustained rise in crude prices quickly spreads through the wider economy.

When sanctions meet market reality

Global oil markets are operating with little room for psychological comfort. The world has already seen disruptions in the Red Sea, attacks on shipping infrastructure, growing military tensions involving Iran, tighter tanker availability and sharply higher war-risk insurance premiums. In such conditions, constraining one of the world’s largest oil suppliers inevitably unsettles markets, even if physical supply losses remain limited at first.

Oil markets react not only to shortages but also to the fear of shortages. That fear alone can drive prices sharply higher. Ironically, this exposes a contradiction at the heart of the western sanctions policy.

The U.S. and Europe want to reduce Russia’s oil revenues. But they also want lower inflation, stable fuel prices and uninterrupted global energy flows. Increasingly, these objectives are colliding with each other. The harder sanctions become, the greater the risk of tightening global supply balances. Once oil prices rise sufficiently, Russia can continue earning substantial revenues despite lower export volumes. In some cases, higher global prices can partially offset the impact of sanctions themselves. This explains why the sanctions policy has repeatedly oscillated between aggressive rhetoric and tactical flexibility. Markets eventually force pragmatism.

The temporary waivers and carve-outs of recent years were not merely signs of policy inconsistency; they reflected energy-market realities. The uncomfortable truth is that the modern global economy still runs overwhelmingly on hydrocarbons. Despite the rapid growth of renewables, oil remains central to transport, aviation, petrochemicals, agriculture and global trade logistics. The world may speak of transition, but it still functions on molecules.

For India, the challenge is even more complex. The Strait of Hormuz remains a major strategic vulnerability, carrying nearly one-fifth of global

displacing it. The data clearly show India’s continued dependence on coal. Despite strong renewable growth since 2017, India has added almost no new fossil fuel capacity since 2018, retired very few old coal plants, and seen gas-based capacity decline. As a result, coal remains the main backup and balancing source in the power system.

The reasons are structural. Solar and wind power remain intermittent sources of electricity. Their output fluctuates with weather conditions and the time of day, while electricity demand remains continuous. In the absence of large-scale battery storage, flexible grids and adequate balancing capacity, coal continues to provide the baseload reliability required to keep the system functioning.

This also explains why domestic electricity prices remain closely tied to global fossil fuel markets. Historical trends show Indian electricity prices moving alongside Brent crude in the last few years. Even sectors that appear domestically anchored remain indirectly exposed to external commodity cycles because fossil fuels continue to determine marginal cost of power.

Ground reality

As a result, current geopolitical tensions in West Asia affect India more severely. A spike in crude prices not only raises transportation and industrial costs directly, but also pushes up coal prices, electricity tariffs, inflation, and fiscal pressures.

India’s energy transition discourse is increasingly centred around the wrong benchmark. The focus remains on installed renewable capacity because it offers an attractive measure of progress. Yet, power systems are not sustained by headline capacity additions. They depend on actual electricity generation and the

oil trade. A large share of India’s crude oil and LPG imports transit through these waters. Any escalation in the region could disrupt supplies, raise shipping costs and delay deliveries. This is why Russian crude evolved into something larger than a discounted barrel for Asia. It emerged as a diversification mechanism during a period of growing uncertainty in West Asia.

The larger lesson from these developments is that energy security itself is changing shape. In earlier decades, countries were concerned mainly with access to physical supply. Today, vulnerabilities are far more complex. Energy flows can now be disrupted by shipping restrictions, insurance controls, financial sanctions, tanker blacklisting, payment barriers and maritime security risks. In effect, global energy has become deeply entangled with financial and geopolitical architecture.

India’s long-term energy strategy

This changing landscape has major implications for India’s long-term strategy. India cannot rely indefinitely on opportunistic crude sourcing during crises. The country needs a broader and more resilient energy framework. That means expanding strategic petroleum reserves, diversifying crude sourcing regions, strengthening domestic exploration, improving refining flexibility, accelerating gas infrastructure, expanding alternative energy pathways and reducing dependence on vulnerable maritime chokepoints. At the same time, India will need to preserve strategic autonomy in energy decision-making.

The emerging global order is becoming increasingly fragmented. Energy trade is no longer governed purely by economics; it is increasingly shaped by sanctions regimes, strategic rivalries and competing geopolitical blocs. For major importing countries, excessive dependence on any single geopolitical camp carries long-term risks. India’s approach therefore reflects not neutrality, but realism.

The years ahead are likely to witness repeated tensions between geopolitical objectives and energy-market stability. The world is entering an era in which sanctions, wars, maritime insecurity and supply-chain disruptions may become recurring features rather than temporary exceptions. That makes resilience more important than ideology. In the end, energy systems obey physical realities, not political slogans. Tankers must still move. Refineries must still operate. Economies must still function. Nations that fail to build diversified and resilient energy systems may discover that, in the 21st century, economic sovereignty increasingly depends on the ability to navigate a fragmented and unstable energy world.

ability to supply power consistently when it is needed most.

The distinction matters because it shapes perceptions of vulnerability. China remains less exposed, with oil and gas accounting for only 4% of its power mix and electric vehicles and hybrids, now over half of new car sales, reducing oil demand by over a million barrels a day. Spain shows the alternative, having broken the gas-electricity link through renewables. India’s transition is real, but incomplete.

Work towards system transformation

This does not diminish the importance of the renewable push. On the contrary, India’s decision to aggressively scale solar and wind capacity since the late 2010s now appears prescient given growing geopolitical instability and fossil fuel volatility. But the next phase of transition will require moving beyond capacity creation towards system transformation itself.

That means investing in storage infrastructure, grid modernisation, transmission connectivity and market mechanisms capable of integrating intermittent renewables at scale. It also requires recognising that coal’s persistence is not simply a policy failure or institutional inertia. Coal currently performs a stabilising function within the grid that renewable energy, in its present form, cannot yet fully replicate.

India’s energy challenge today is therefore not merely about producing more green power. It is about building an electricity system in which renewables can reliably substitute for fossil fuels in actual generation. Until that happens, every geopolitical crisis and every spike in global energy prices will continue to remind India that its green transition still runs on coal.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Significance of the CJP

The growing popularity of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) points to a deeper problem – many institutions today seem to lack transparency and a meaningful connection with the people. There is also a growing perception that some of them are giving up their independent voice and avoiding speaking truth to power. Therefore, the issues raised by the party, such as unemployment, examination irregularities, and ministerial

accountability, have clearly struck a chord. In our democratic system, parties in power often appear unwilling to listen to criticism or feedback unless it takes the form of a massive public protest, and this continues for five long years.

V. Nagarajan,
Chennai

The rise of the CJP only underlines the digital power of India’s youth. It also reflects a deeper reality – India’s youth want to be

heard. It has already succeeded in starting conversations around unemployment, governance, and freedom of expression. The real question now is whether this viral rebellion can evolve into a durable political force. Nevertheless, for now the cockroach has truly crawled across the political floors of the BJP, creating tension and concern within the ruling establishment.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Restraint over contestation

Beneath a Hindu temple, one may uncover a Buddhist structure; beneath that may lie yet another forgotten past. Such discoveries reveal the continuity and evolution of civilisation across centuries. Endless attempts to reclaim historical ownership through courts and excavations risk deepening social divisions and perpetuating inherited grievances. A nation as diverse as India requires constitutional restraint,

historical humility, and civic wisdom. Public discourse should strengthen social harmony and mutual coexistence.

Harsh Pawaria,
Rohtak, Haryana

Tamil Nadu cabinet

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay should be credited for his timely inclusion of an MLA from the VCK and another from the IUML in his Cabinet. By giving due representation to socio-religious minorities, he has reaffirmed the

secular credentials of both his party and his government. Such inclusion is not only a constitutional imperative but also serves as an effective check against the BJP, which is attempting to gradually expand its presence. Such representation will make governance more broad-based and democratic.

N.G.R. Prasad,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Busting two myths around Bengal polls

From the century-old red edifice of Lal Bari, the Writers' Building, once the seat of Bengal's colonial and postcolonial bureaucracy, and from where the BJP had promised to govern, to Nabanna, Bengal's Neelbari, the blue and white Secretariat that came to embody Mamata Banerjee's aesthetic and political imprint, and further to the historic chambers of the West Bengal Legislative Assembly, the sudden wash of saffron light was not merely a matter of altered decor. It felt like a visual declaration of a deeper political rupture in a State that had, for decades, imagined itself resistant to the crudities of communal binaries.

The rise of the Bharatiya Janata Party in Bengal cannot be explained through electoral arithmetic alone. The 2026 Assembly election verdict, which gave the BJP 207 of 294 seats with 45.84% of the vote, while reducing the Trinamool Congress to 80 seats with 40.8%, unsettled much conventional political wisdom. The Left Front and Congress, once central to Bengal's political imagination, were reduced to a combined 7.42%. But numbers alone tell only the surface story. Beneath them lies a longer tale of political exhaustion, organisational patience, and the collapse of older certainties.

Two convenient myths have quickly emerged. The first is that 2026 witnessed a dramatic fresh migration of traditional Left and Congress voters directly to the BJP. The second is that Bengal simply succumbed to an all encompassing Hindu consolidation. Both explanations are politically convenient and analytically lazy. Bengal's political shifts have rarely followed such neat trajectories.

The BJP's ascent was neither abrupt nor principally the result of a sudden Left exodus. Historically, the party's greatest obstacle in Bengal was not the Left but Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress. When Ms. Banerjee broke away from the Congress,



Sayantan Ghosh

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In politics, the moment power begins to imagine itself invincible, the electorate begins to search, desperately if necessary, for the sharpest available instrument with which to puncture that illusion

she successfully occupied the anti-Left political space, leaving little room for the BJP. During the Atal Bihari Vajpayee years, she was part of the National Democratic Alliance, and the BJP remained peripheral in Bengal's political imagination.

The real shift came later under Amit Shah, when the BJP's organisational relationship with the RSS acquired sharper purpose. The RSS had maintained a quiet presence in Bengal for decades. From this ecosystem emerged Dilip Ghosh, deputed to build what the BJP had long lacked, a serious grassroots machine. Yet even then, the breakthrough was slow. In 2016, the BJP won only three seats with around 10% of the vote.

The real erosion of the Left support began after that, accelerated by the Trinamool dominance and the violence that increasingly accompanied political contestation. The 2018 panchayat elections became a grim marker, with at least a dozen deaths reported around polling and a wider climate of intimidation. For many grassroots supporters, politics ceased to be ideological and became existential. Those who once looked to the Left or Congress for protection increasingly found those structures incapable of defending them.

By 2021, despite an alliance that also included Abbas Siddiqui's Indian Secular Front, the Left-Congress experiment collapsed to around 8.7%. The BJP rose to nearly 38%, while the Trinamool held steady at around 48%. This was not ideological conversion so much as the consolidation of anti-Trinamool sentiment behind the only viable challenger. By 2026, the Left-Congress combine slipped further to 7.42%, while the BJP gained roughly seven percentage points, largely at the Trinamool's expense.

The second myth, that of wholesale Hindu consolidation, also demands caution. Nearly 30%

of Bengal's electorate is Muslim, and the BJP's support there remains negligible. If this had simply been the story of monolithic Hindu consolidation, the BJP's decisive breakthrough should have come in 2021, when the party deployed its most aggressively polarised campaign around the Citizenship Amendment Act and the National Register of Citizens. That strategy helped the BJP rise dramatically from three seats to 77. Yet even then, it fell short. Bengal still held.

What changed in 2026 was not simply the retention of that support, but the movement of an additional section of Hindu voters who had backed Ms. Banerjee in 2021, not out of ideological commitment, but because she appeared the strongest barrier against the BJP. Once disillusionment with the Trinamool deepened, that tactical resistance weakened. The nearly seven percentage point shift from the Trinamool to the BJP cannot therefore be read simply as religious consolidation. It was anti-incumbency finding its most effective electoral vehicle.

The BJP would be mistaken if it chose to read this verdict as a sweeping ideological embrace of Hindutva in Bengal. This was not, in any simple sense, Bengal surrendering to saffron. It was Bengal reaching for saffron as an instrument of protest, draping itself in a colour not necessarily out of devotion, but out of despair, anger, and exhaustion. This was less an affirmation of the BJP's grand ideological project than a fierce indictment of a regime that appeared, to many, to have grown distant, complacent, and convinced of its own permanence.

There is a warning here that extends beyond party lines. In politics, the moment power begins to imagine itself invincible, the electorate begins to search, desperately if necessary, for the sharpest available instrument with which to puncture that illusion. In Bengal, for many voters, the BJP became that instrument.

A rollback, at last

Karnataka govt. lifts order that banned faith markers, including hijab, in schools

STATE OF PLAY

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In what was called an "emergency" press conference last week, Karnataka's Minister for School Education and Literacy Madhu Bangarappa announced the rollback of the 2022 order on uniforms in schools and pre-university colleges. The controversial order of the previous BJP government had led to hijab-donning girls being barred from entering classrooms. It started with six Muslim girls in hijab being prevented from entering their classroom in the coastal town of Udupi, spread quickly across the State, and reached the High Court and eventually the Supreme Court.

Though the rollback was a manifesto promise of the Congress, the government had been dragging its feet on it for nearly three years. In fact, Chief Minister Siddaramaiah had a few months after the party's stellar victory in 2023 elections made a public announcement that people can "wear whatever they want, eat whatever they want", only to clarify the next day that no formal order had been issued and the government was only considering revocation after discussion with officials.

The rather sudden announcement of the rollback has come in between two significant political developments. It came soon after the Congress managed a narrow victory in the bypolls to Davanagere South, a constituency with a significant Muslim population. The run-up to the bypolls had seen an intense push by Muslim leaders for the Congress to field a candidate from the community, but to no avail.

Following this, there were allegations of anti-party activity leading to the suspension of MLC Abdul Jabbar from the primary membership of the Congress and the removal of Naseer Ahmed from his post as Chief Minister's political secretary. It also came just ahead of "Karnataka Muslim Empowerment and Accountability Summit" to seek answers from the Congress on the promises to the community made but not kept, the rollback of the uniform rule being one of them. The document released at the convention spoke of the hijab ban as "one of the most painful and visible symbols of exclusion faced by Muslim girls in Karnataka." It cited the People's Union of Civil Liberties-Karnataka report "Closing the Gates to Education" that documented how hijab restrictions affected Muslim girl students' right to education and dignity.

The carefully-worded new order that came on May 13 (three days prior to the convention) on uniform allows "limited traditional and faith-based symbols" and mentions hijab, turban, janivara (sacred thread), and rudraksha, along with the prescribed uniform. The order also prohibits authorities from compelling students to remove these symbols, which came in the context of some Brahmin students being asked to remove their janivara during the recent Common Entrance Test,

a qualifying exam for Engineering courses in the State. The order was a clear balancing act in anticipation of the BJP dubbing it "appeasement politics". Mr. Madhu Bangarappa was flanked by his Cabinet colleague Dinesh Gundu Rao, a Brahmin, on one side and MLA Rizwan Arshad on the other, as if to further drive home this point.

All this effort, of course, has not prevented the BJP leaders from calling it "appeasement." Mr. Siddaramaiah has responded to this by asking why allowing the hijab is appeasement, while allowing janivara or turban is not. He also clarified that saffron shawls, which many students (mostly male) wore in protest against hijab being allowed in classrooms back in 2022, would not be allowed in educational institutes. In fact, the order's emphasis on "limited traditional and faith-based symbols" too seems to anticipate this.

But whether there will be an orchestrated effort for saffron shawls to enter classrooms, along with hijab, remains to be seen. Vijayapura MLA Basanagouda Patil Yarnal, who has been expelled from the BJP but remains a Hindutva rabble-rouser, has already said that he would launch a movement to counter hijab by asking students to wear saffron shawls and tilak to school. He even said that whenever teachers call out attendance, students would be asked to respond with a "Jai Sri Ram."

As schools and colleges are set to reopen for the next academic year, how this will pan out and how firmly the Congress government will handle it remains to be seen. Meanwhile, in the Supreme Court, following a split verdict, the hijab case awaits hearing by a larger bench.

Now, only two young States haven't had a coalition govt.

With Vijay's TVK regime accommodating its allies in its Cabinet, Tamil Nadu has joined eight other States ruled by coalition governments in 2026

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis
Pon Vasanth B.A.
Iwaala Narasimhan

On May 13, 2026, when the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam led by C. Joseph Vijay, which fell short of the 118 seats needed to form a government, won the vote of confidence in the Tamil Nadu (T.N.) Assembly, history repeated itself in the State.

In 1952, the T.N. Assembly became the first legislative body in Independent India to witness a motion of no confidence, which the Congress party won after C. Rajagopalachari formed the first coalition government in the country. For the next 74 years, Tamil Nadu remained among a handful of outliers in the country to have never had a coalition government, mainly due to the domination of the DMK and the AIADMK. Even in 2006 when the DMK fell short of a majority, it did not have to accommodate its allies in the Cabinet.

Though Mr. Vijay had expressed his party's willingness to share power even in 2024, the fractured mandate made it a necessity to accommodate the Congress, the VCK and the IUML in the Cabinet.

Now, only the young States of Chhattisgarh and Telangana, formed respectively in 2000 and 2014, remain the outliers among the major States by never having a coalition government (**Chart 1**).

The dominance of the Congress was first challenged in the 1967 elections, a crucial point in India's politics as the party failed to secure a majority in a number of major States, including Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, T.N., and Kerala.

This shift towards coalitions and the emergence of regional parties is also reflected in the number of parties represented in the Lok Sabha from 1967 (**Chart 2**). It also shows the emergence of the BJP.

(With inputs from Sambavi Parthasarathy and Devyanshi Bihani)

Share in power

The data for the charts are sourced from the Election Commission of India and Lok Dhaba. The dataset maintained KK. Kailash, Professor, Department of Political Science, University of Hyderabad, was used for verification for some years

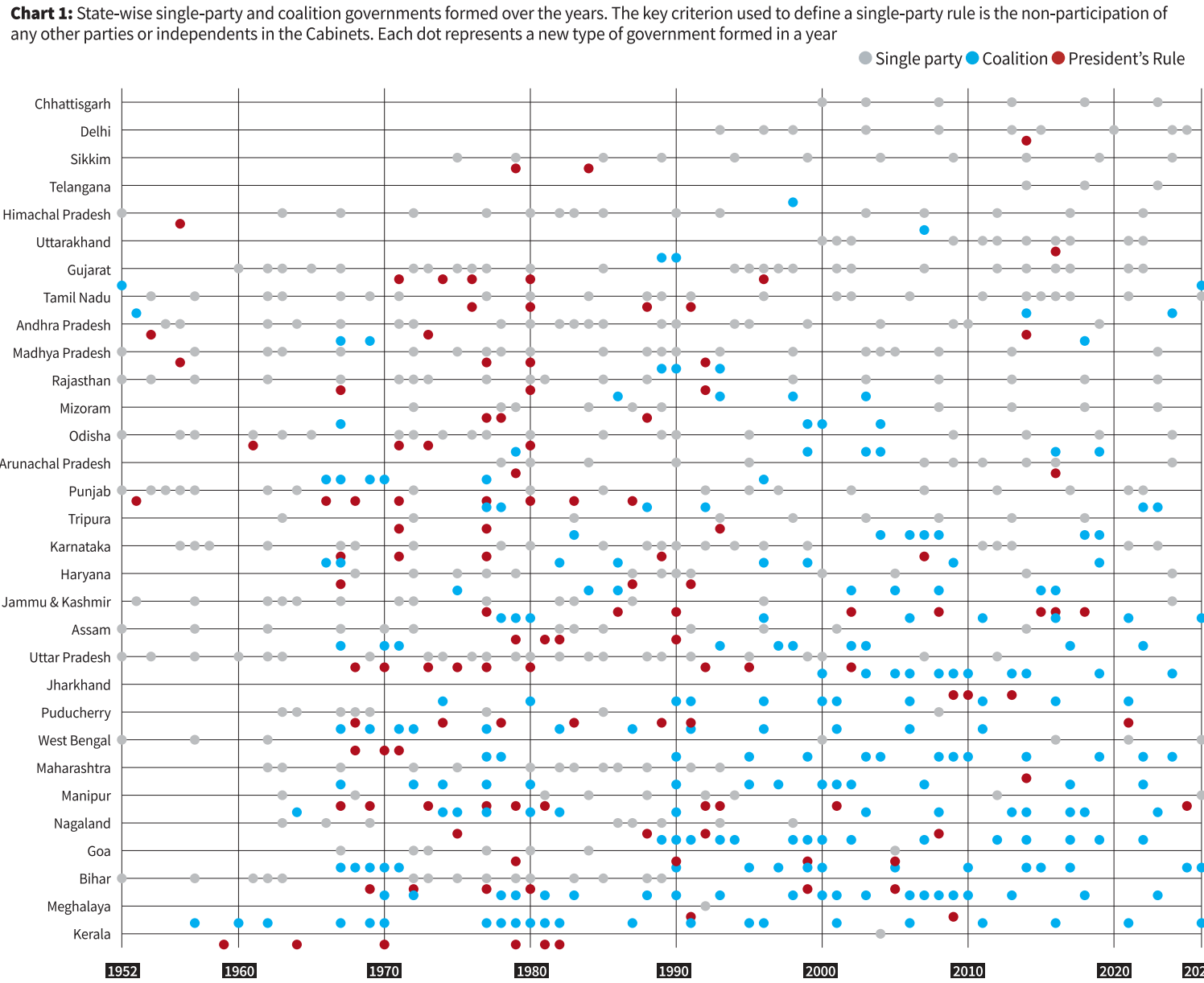
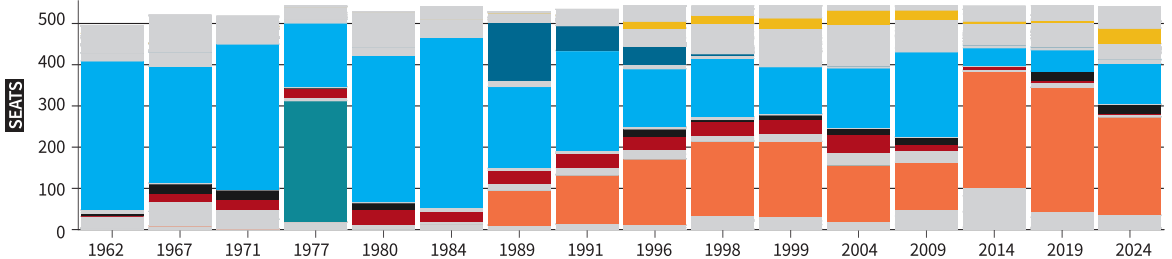


Chart 2: The number of parties represented in the Lok Sabha sharply increased in 1967. This trend, after peaking in the 1990s, declined with the BJP's emergence as the single largest party in 2014

Legend: INC (blue), BJP (orange), Janata Party (green), CPI(M) (red), Samajwadi Party (yellow), DMK (black), Janata Dal (teal), Others (grey)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO MAY 25, 1976

HMT's expansion plans in watch-making

MADRAS, May 24.: The Hindustan Machine Tools Factory, Bangalore, is expected to reach the Rs. 250 crore turnover during the Sixth Plan period, when it would have introduced many new product lines.

The HMT has received permission from the Central Government to expand its watch production capacity from one to three million watches. HMT engineers are now in Switzerland attending an important fair, where machine tools for watch-making are being exhibited. A high-power delegation led by the Executive Director of the HMT Watch Factory is now in Geneva to negotiate suppliers' credit. Mr. S. M. Patil, HMT Chairman, was recently in Geneva for preliminary discussions on credit negotiations.

Disclosing this here today, Mr. Patil told pressmen that the project report for the watch-making expansion would be submitted to the Government of India in two or three months.

He said the Union Government, as part of its Hill Area Development Programme, would help the Sikkim Government to set up a sub-assembly unit for HMT watches.

Darjeeling was another centre selected by the Central Government. All the watches assembled at these sub-assembly centres would be marketed by the HMT.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MAY 25, 1926

Antiquity of football

This year's F. A. Cup Final arouses widespread interest in a very ancient game.

"The Daily Herald" recalls that the Chinese played a kind of football ages ago. The winners of a match were always regaled with a great "feed" and acclaimed as heroes, but the losers dared not lift their heads for shame, and the losing captain was invariably flogged!

There were numerous attempts to prohibit the game in Mediaeval England, and Elizabeth's reign found the "murderous game of ball" forbidden on pain of imprisonment. But the people could not be denied a fast improving game, and so football came into its own. It was played in all sorts of queer places, but most often across the open country.

In some instances the goals were several miles apart, and whole villages played each other.

A CH-CHE

Apply for a personal loan after reading this

Santosh Agarwal

When looking for a personal loan, your credit profile, income stability, employer profile and existing obligations are evaluated closely by lenders. Even small gaps can lead to higher borrowing costs or outright rejection. Here are a few aspects you should consider before you apply for a personal loan.

High credit score

One of the primary metrics of assessment is the credit profile of the borrower. A strong credit profile with a credit score of 760 or above positions borrowers as strong applicants and may help you get the loan at lower interest rates and preferential loan terms. However, a credit score below 700 directly pushes you into the high-cost or rejection bucket.

Reaching the threshold requires consistent and disciplined efforts like repaying dues on time, avoiding multiple loan applications within a short period of time, keeping credit utilisation low and more.

Stable income

Lenders assess mainly two aspects of a borrower – intent and capacity to pay. While the intent to pay is established using the credit profile of the borrower, the capacity to repay is derived from the income of the borrower. Even though the general notion stands that high income supports easy loan approval, contradictions remain. High income may be an important signal, but the stability of that high income matters equally. A consistent, stable income is given preference over a fluctuating high income.

Salaried consumers employed with the central or state governments, large MNCs, reputed private organisations and those with more than a couple of years of stable employment have a more predictable income trend. Lenders perceive it as less risky and may offer loans at lower rates and better terms. On the other hand, an unstable employment record with frequent job hopping can lower your chances of approval.

Existing credit burden

Existing debt obligations can also potentially shrink the room for fresh credit. Lenders prefer applicants to have their debt to obligation ratio within 50-55% including the EMI of the proposed loan. Individuals planning for fresh credit should take their existing obligations into account and bring their debt within the lenders' preferred bracket to boost their chances of approval. Paying off smaller loans or restructuring existing debt can help bring the ratio within a comfortable range and improve eligibility.

Keep documents ready

Any error or discrepancy in documents may also lead to rejection. Before submitting documents, borrowers should thoroughly review it and correct errors, if any. At the same time, borrowers should update details in the documents, if needed. Before applying, they should keep their employment and income records, bank statements, along with KYC documents such as PAN and Aadhaar ready for submission.

Choose the right lender

Eligibility criteria may vary across lenders. One of the most optimal ways of boosting approval chances involves shortlisting lenders whose eligibility criteria you meet comfortably. Also, don't forget to check for personalised offers from banks and NBFCs where you have an existing relationship. Comparing loan offers first and selecting the most suitable one not only increases your chances of approval but also limits the number of hard inquiries.

Apply for an optimal amount

One common mistake is applying for the maximum loan amount you are eligible for rather than the loan amount you actually need. Higher loan amounts usually carry higher risk for lenders, thus inviting stricter scrutiny. Applying for a loan amount in line with your repayment capacity and current obligations boost your chances of approval.

(The writer is CEO, Paisabazaar)



Humans rarely realise that every lifestyle upgrade silently resets the approval baseline, pushing the line of “approval or success” even higher. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

The costly cave of endless human desires

A man, an alien and a monk decipher the mysteries of desire and its financial implications. Together, they unravel the hidden psychology behind man's conquest of money

HEDONIC RACE

Vaishali R. Venkat

You and I are on a mysterious journey to a financial wilderness. This is not time travel. No ticking clocks or vanishing calendars. Neither the past lingers nor the future unfolds. Deep within this wilderness lies a cave wherein Master Time has imprisoned three strangers, while silently walking beside us all along.

Meet the three cave dwellers. First is Alien Aurum, who remains deeply baffled by man, money and the strange psychology binding them together. To him, money is merely a worthless artefact man endlessly accumulates on what he considers an unfamiliar planet. Another dweller is Man Midas, who turns many things into gold, yet grows increasingly bankrupt in happiness.

At the edge of the cave stands the third stranger, Monk Moneywise, a pragmatist who broke free from the consumer loop, mastered the math of “enough,” and who acts as a torch-bearer for those still trapped.

Let's watch the play inside the cave. Every time Midas earns more money, he upgrades his life. His bullock cart becomes a horse cart, leaf-woven clothes turn into fine cotton, the walls of his cave glitter with teakwood, and the cow-dung-smeared floors transform into polished wooden flooring. He does all this hoping that he



“Humans often confuse upgrading their lifestyle with upgrading their lives, and that's why they chase wealth constantly”

would be happy forever. Yet his joy vanishes into thin air like a bubble.

Deeply puzzled, Alien Aurum begins tracing the roots of this behaviour to a strange human ritual: spending enormous energy, and money, impressing people who are themselves exhausted by impressing others. Alien Aurum asks, “Mr. Moneywise, if humans become unhappy so quickly after getting whatever they wished for, why do they spend their entire lives wishing for more?”

Wearing a faint smile, Monk Moneywise says, “Humans often confuse upgrading their lifestyle with upgrading their lives, and that's why they chase wealth constantly. What once felt luxurious gradually becomes mundane, and his desire starts chasing again. They are not just chasing money, Aurum, but society's approvals and appreciations too. The cruel part: they rarely realise that every lifestyle upgrade resets the baseline for approval, pushing the line of “approval or success” even higher. The more the income, the more the society raises the baseline.”

Alien Aurum asks in bewilderment, “So humans keep running faster to feel more successful, only to



“Humans keep running harder towards newer desires and upgrades, yet emotionally remain in the same place”

discover that success itself keeps moving further away like a mirage?” Monk Moneywise clarifies, “What you are witnessing, Aurum, is what behavioural psychologists Philip Brickman and Donald T. Campbell called the “hedonic treadmill,” also called hedonic adaptation. Humans keep running harder and harder towards newer desires, yet emotionally remain in the same place, like a treadmill that never truly moves forward.”

Staring at Midas' glittering cave, the monk continues, “Aurum, bigger caves demand bigger maintenance costs. Faster carts demand more feeding for horses, and the tragedy is that lifestyle inflation converts rising income into rising financial commitments. Instead of bringing comfort, higher income often ends up bringing only bigger expenses and shrinking financial breathing space. Soon, Midas is no longer working for financial freedom; but he is working harder just to maintain his lifestyle he once believed would set him free.”

Man Midas interrupts with visible anger. “It's easy to judge humans from a distance. An alien does not understand planet Earth, human life or its complexi-

ties. And the monk walked away long ago from the responsibilities and burdens of life. Try raising a family in metropolitan cities where people measure your worth through income, clothes, possessions and overall richness. We have no choice but to run. If we stop, those running behind us will trample over us and move ahead. We are not merely buying comfort. Some are buying respect, identity, social acceptance, and at times, even survival itself.” All of a sudden, thunder roars across the wilderness. The cave falls silent. Somewhere in the darkness, Master Time has been carefully listening to all three without judgement. Time whispers into the ears of those chasing money: “I have watched humans for centuries. They mortgage their future selves heavily, trading tomorrow's peace, health and freedom to decorate their present lives.

Next week, I shall tell you how humans eventually become prisoners of the lifestyle they once dreamt of.” Monk Moneywise says softly, “Not all lessons are learnt through wisdom, Aurum. The costliest ones are revealed only by Master Time. Let us wait to witness what Time has to unfold.” And the voice of Master Time echoes through the wilderness, “Monk Moneywise has mastered the art of ‘enough’ and so, it no longer fears the grip of Time.”

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 99
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	9.60 onwards	10,525 onwards	2,105 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.25% (Rs 500 - Rs 2,500)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	8.75-13.55	10,319-11,518	2,064-2,304	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	50% waiver on [0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)]
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.90 - 9.85	10,355 - 10,587	Rs 750 - Rs 1,500
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.30	10,078 - 10,452	Rs 2,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.35 onwards	10,222 onwards	Up to 2%
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.01-11.51	10,141 - 10,999	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Federal Bank	7.60-9.00	10,198 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank**	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.30	10,043 - 10,452	0.50%(Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 20,000)

*0.25% rate concession for home loan borrowers, existing customers with at least 6 months relationship with bank
**Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on May 20

Source: Paisabazaar.com

When prepaying loan is optimal

THINKINVESTOR

For most, the sooner they pay off a loan, the less anxious they feel; it is then emotionally optimal to prepay the loan

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Our investing and spending decisions require trade-offs. We typically weigh these trade-offs but often arrive at a decision based on our emotions. In this article, we discuss one such trade-off you may face. If you just received an unexpected amount of cashflow either from an inheritance or from a long-forgotten claim, what will you do: Invest the money or prepay your existing loan?

For most, the sooner they pay off a loan, the less anxious they feel. If you are one of them, then it is emotionally optimal to prepay the loan. For others, a simple back-of-the-envelope calculation is useful. This involves comparing the expected investment returns with interest saved by prepaying the loan. Suppose you invest the cash flow in a fund with expected post-tax returns of 10%. If the interest rate on the loan is 9%, then you should invest the amount and continue paying your loan as per the original schedule. This is because the investment return is greater than the interest rate paid on the loan. Also, if this loan is towards your self-occupied house, you are building equity in the property as you repay your loan, in addition to investing the unexpected cash flow. Some who are risk-takers may even choose to invest the cash flow in derivatives to increase returns.

The above argument does not consider income variability. What if your current employment is an industry that has seen massive disruptions because of AI? If you feel anxious about your future income, are you comfortable carrying a loan? If not, it may be better to prepay the loan. Note that if you are concerned about your future income, it is highly unlikely that you will invest aggressively. That means you are more likely to lean towards bonds than equity; the expected returns on the investments are likely to be lower than the interest rate on the loan.

The decision between prepaying a loan and investing the cash is one of the many trade-offs we must make. Other trade-offs include buying a house or renting one for self-occupation. If all these decisions are based on simple economics, life would be easier. Unfortunately, we often yield to our emotions which can bias our decisions. So, what is optimal from an emotional perspective may not always be economically meaningful. But emotions are important for a holistic financial wellbeing. Therefore, prepaying a loan with unexpected cash may be optimal.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

DOING IT MY WAY

I have taken a lot of brave calls, that’s how I like to lead: Parag



EMMANUAL YOGINI

I have taken a lot of brave calls, that’s how I like to lead. You’ve got to take your chances, it’s not a gamble. Of course, you think about it a lot. I thought only Jofra Archer could get Hardik Pandya, and that’s what he did. I always go by my instinct in making real-time decisions — Riyan Parag, Rajasthan Royals skipper.

ROOM FOR IMPROVEMENT

There are a lot of areas where we can do better: RR captain



EMMANUAL YOGINI

Captain Riyan Parag, while happy with qualifying for the playoffs, stressed that Rajasthan Royals needed to make big improvements heading into the Eliminator against Sunrisers Hyderabad. “It’s obviously good when things go to plan. I know we’ve won the game, we’ve qualified, but there are a lot of areas where we can do better”.

CANDID POLLARD

‘We weren’t able to string together wins and use the momentum’



EMMANUAL YOGINI

We weren’t good throughout the tournament. We weren’t able to string together wins and use the momentum when we got it. When you look at it rationally, we got the position that we deserved — MI batting coach Kieron Pollard, adding that all aspects would be reviewed internally though no immediate decisions were likely.

NOT OUR TIME

Hardik was trying, we were trying... it just didn’t work out: Pollard



EMMANUAL YOGINI

MI batting coach Kieron Pollard admitted that skipper Hardik Pandya’s leadership stint “has not gone as well as he would have wanted as an individual.” “Hardik was trying; we all were trying, and it just didn’t work out for us. You sit, you talk, [and] see what is the best. Never know what is going to happen,” he said.

Archer’s all-round show guides Royals into playoffs

The Englishman’s batting cameo and incisive three-wicket spell help Parag’s men earn the final last-four spot; Suryakumar and Hardik’s efforts go in vain as MI finishes the season with 10 losses

IPL-19

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

For a while on Sunday evening, Suryakumar Yadav and captain Hardik Pandya kept Mumbai Indians alive in a contest that seemed to be slipping away from the home team.

But Jofra Archer’s decisive all-round intervention ensured Rajasthan Royals sealed the fourth and final IPL 2026 playoff spot in style at the Wankhede Stadium. Had it not been for Archer’s late flourish with the bat and fiery burst with the ball, RR may well have been left ruing another near-miss – a feeling that the eliminated Punjab Kings will now know all too well.

Eyebrows raised

When Archer walked in at No. 7 in the 13th over, ahead of designated finisher Shubham Dubey and Impact Player option Ravindra Jadeja, a few eyebrows were raised. But the Englishman repaid the faith instantly, muscling the ball nonchalantly to the boundary and injecting momentum into an innings where run flow had stalled for a brief period.

His cameo (32, 15b, 1x4, 3x6) proved crucial as RR



In the pink of form: Archer accounted for Rohit, Naman and Hardik. EMMANUAL YOGINI

plundered 73 runs off the final five overs to post 205 for eight against an underperforming MI unit.

Archer struck straightaway with the ball. He forced an edge off Rohit Sharma in the opening ov-

er before cleaning up Naman Dhir with a sharp delivery. Yet, with Suryakumar surviving a

SCOREBOARD

RAJASTHAN ROYALS

Yashasvi Jaiswal c Bosch b Jacks 27 (17b, 1x4, 3x6), Vaibhav Sooryavanshi c Naman b Chahar 4 (6b), Dhruv Jurel b Bosch 38 (26b, 3x4, 2x6), Riyan Parag c Tilak b Ghazanfar 14 (8b, 2x4, 1x6), Dasun Shanaka run out 29 (15b, 3x6), Donovan Ferreira c Bosch b Chahar 18 (15b, 2x6), Jofra Archer c Tilak b Shardul 32 (15b, 1x4, 3x6), Shubham Dubey c Naman b Shardul 5 (6b), Ravindra Jadeja (Impact Player for Shubham) (not out) 19 (11b, 3x4), Nandre Burger (not out) 10 (3b, 1x6); Extras (lb-1, nb-2, w-6): 9; Total (for eight wkts. in 20 overs): 205.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-33 (Jaiswal, 3.4 overs), 2-33 (Sooryavanshi, 4.1), 3-54 (Parag, 5.6), 4-99 (Shanaka, 10.3), 5-119 (Jurel, 12.5), 6-139 (Ferreira, 15.3), 7-174 (Shubham, 17.4), 8-175 (Archer, 17.6).

MUMBAI INDIANS BOWLING

Chahar 4-0-43-2, Jacks 2-0-12-1, Ghazanfar 3-0-45-1, Raghu 3-0-25-0, Shardul 4-0-41-2, Bosch 4-0-38-1.

MUMBAI INDIANS

chance at midwicket off Yash Raj’s leg-spin and Hardik beginning to find his rhythm, the Mumbai franchise threatened to script a memorable chase for the 19,000-odd schoolchildren in attendance under MI owners’ Education and Sports For All initiative.

But Archer returned in the 16th over to produce a vicious short ball that Hardik could not handle, deci-

sively swinging the game the visiting side’s way. Earlier, MI had rested Jasprit Bumrah and Hardik did not bowl, but teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi failed to light up the venue. After Will Jacks’ acrobatic save converted a certain six into a single, Sooryavanshi fell into a deep-point trap off Deepak Chahar. Yashasvi Jaiswal provided an explosive start

Rohit Sharma (Impact Player for Raghu) c Jurel b Archer 0 (4b), Ryan Rickelton c Sooryavanshi b Burger 12 (7b, 1x4, 1x6), Naman Dhir b Archer 6 (5b, 1x4), Suryakumar Yadav c & b Burger 60 (42b, 3x4, 4x6), Tilak Varma b Brijesh 3 (7b), Will Jacks c Jurel b Yash Raj 33 (18b, 3x4, 2x6), Hardik Pandya c Burger b Archer 34 (15b, 3x4, 2x6), Corbin Bosch c Ferreira b Yash Raj 2 (4b), Shardul Thakur (not out) 10 (11b, 1x4), Deepak Chahar lbw b Brijesh 8 (5b, 1x6), A.M. Ghazanfar (not out) 2 (3b); Extras (nb-1, w-4): 5; Total (for nine wkts. in 20 overs): 175.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-0 (Rohit, 0.4), 2-18 (Naman, 2.3), 3-24 (Rickelton, 3.2), 4-38 (Tilak, 5.1), 5-101 (Jacks, 11.3), 6-149 (Hardik, 15.4), 7-152 (Bosch, 16.3), 8-158 (Suryakumar, 17.3), 9-167 (Chahar, 18.3).

ROYALS BOWLING

Archer 4-0-17-3, Burger 4-0-43-2, Brijesh 4-0-26-2, Jadeja 2-0-24-0, Yash Raj 4-0-44-2, Shanaka 2-0-21-0.

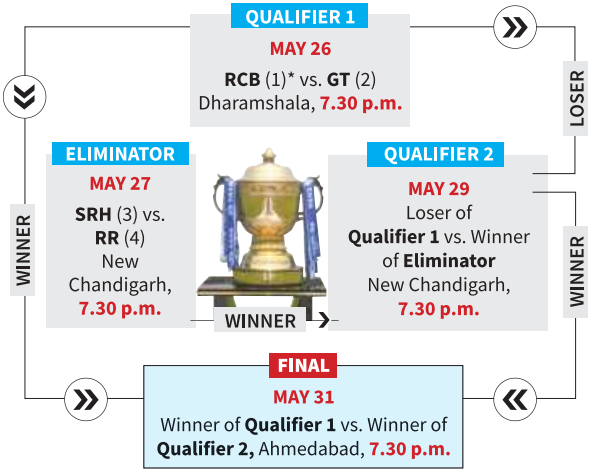
Toss: MI; PoM: Archer. Royals won by 30 runs.

Final points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Royal Challengers (Q)	14	9	5	0	18	0.783
Gujarat Titans (Q)	14	9	5	0	18	0.695
Sunrisers Hyderabad (Q)	14	9	5	0	18	0.524
Rajasthan Royals (Q)	14	8	6	0	16	0.189
Punjab Kings	14	7	6	1	15	0.309
Delhi Capitals	14	7	7	0	14	-0.651
Kolkata Knight Riders	14	6	7	1	13	-0.147
Chennai Super Kings	14	6	8	0	12	-0.345
Mumbai Indians	14	4	10	0	8	-0.584
Lucknow Super Giants	14	4	10	0	8	-0.740

Q: Qualified

The Playoffs Schedule



*Numbers in brackets indicate the position of the team after the league phase

Rahul and Kuldeep shine in Capitals’ win

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

K.L. Rahul’s aggressive knock (60, 30b, 5x4, 4x6) set up Delhi Capitals’ 40-run win over Kolkata Knight Riders at the Eden Gardens here on Sunday.

Though the contest lost its significance as early as the fourth over when Rajasthan Royals sealed the final IPL 2026 playoff berth with a win over Mumbai Indians, the 33,000-strong crowd which stayed back

was treated to an entertaining batting display by Rahul. He began cautiously even as his opening partner Abishek Porel provided the spark during the PowerPlay.

After the left-hander departed for 22 in the fifth over – he was caught behind by Tejasvi Singh off impressive left-arm seamer Saurabh Dubey – Rahul took charge.

Capitals’ senior pro went after the bowlers, particularly the spin duo of

Sunil Narine and Varun Chakaravarthi.

After Narine sent back Sahil Parakh for 24, Rahul was involved in a 38-run partnership with skipper Axar Patel for the third wicket. The two plundered 20 off the 11th over bowled by pacer Kartik Tyagi, with Rahul smashing a six and a boundary and Axar chipping in with two fours.

The explosive David Miller provided the final flourish, his breezy 19-ball 28 with three towering six-

es taking the visitors to 203 for five.

In reply, captain Ajinkya Rahane (63, 39b, 4x4, 4x6) waged a lone battle before the hosts were bundled out for 163. Kuldeep Yadav spun a web around the KKR batters, dismissing Rahane and Rinku Singh off consecutive balls.

The left-arm wrist spinner was unlucky to miss a hat-trick as Porel failed to pouch an edge off Tejasvi. Kuldeep finished with figures of 4-0-29-3.

SCOREBOARD

DELHI CAPITALS

Abishek Porel c Tejasvi b Saurabh 22 (18b, 4x4), K.L. Rahul c Powell b Anukul 60 (30b, 5x4, 4x6), Sahil Parakh c Rahane b Narine 24 (17b, 3x4, 1x6), Axar Patel c Rinku b Varun 39 (25b, 3x4, 2x6), David Miller c Allen (Impact Player for Narine) b Saurabh 28 (19b, 3x6), Ashutosh Sharma (not out) 18 (11b, 2x4, 1x6), Tristan Stubbs (not out) 0 (1b); Extras (b-1, lb-2, nb-1, w-8): 12; Total (for five wkts. in 20 overs): 203.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-40 (Porel, 4.3 overs), 2-87 (Pandey, 9.3), 3-125 (Rahul, 12.4), 4-166 (Axar, 16.5), 5-201 (Miller, 19.4).

KNIGHT RIDERS BOWLING

Anukul 2-0-23-1, Saurabh 4-0-28-2, Green 2-0-21-0, Tyagi 4-0-55-0, Narine 4-0-38-1, Varun 4-0-35-1.

KOLKATA KNIGHT RIDERS

Ajinkya Rahane c Miller b Kuldeep 63 (39b, 4x4, 4x6), Finn Allen b Ngidi 20 (13b, 3x4, 1x6), Manish

Pandey c Starc b Ngidi 25 (16b, 2x4, 2x6), Cameron Green c Miller b Kuldeep 2 (3b), Rowman Powell run out 29 (21b, 3x4, 1x6), Rinku Singh c Stubbs b Kuldeep 0 (1b), Tejasvi Singh b Axar 1 (3b), Anukul Roy c & b Starc 9 (8b, 1x4), Kartik Tyagi c Axar b Starc 0 (1b), Varun Chakaravarthi c Axar b Ngidi 5 (5b, 1x4), Saurabh Dubey (not out) 4 (2b, 1x4); Extras (w-5): 5; Total (in 18.4 overs): 163.

FALL OF WICKETS 1-43 (Allen, 4.2), 2-87 (Pandey, 8.3), 3-96 (Green, 9.4), 4-128 (Rahane, 13.2), 5-128 (Rinku, 13.3), 6-129 (Tejasvi, 14.1), 7-154 (Powell, 17.1), 8-154 (Anukul, 17.2), 9-155 (Tyagi, 17.4).

CAPITALS BOWLING

Starc 3-0-26-2, Nabi 2-0-23-0, Ngidi 3.4-0-27-3, Axar 4-0-38-1, Madhav 2-0-20-0, Kuldeep (Impact Player for Rahul) 4-0-29-3.

Toss: KKR; PoM: Kuldeep. Capitals won by 40 runs.



Star turn: Kuldeep spun the contest Capitals’ way. R.V. MOORTHY

Arsenal on a high; Tottenham lives on; Salah, Silva, Guardiola bid goodbyes

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

There was a party atmosphere at Selhurst Park, where Premier League champion Arsenal – which eventually won 2-1 – was given a guard of honour by Crystal Palace before kick-off.

Tottenham survived on a dramatic final day on Sunday as its 1-0 win over Everton condemned West Ham to the Championship despite a 3-0 win against Leeds.

Manchester City boss Pep Guardiola walked out for the final time as manager with newly crowned Europa League winner Aston Villa the visitor.

The occasion also marked the departures of long-serving defender John Stones and midfielder Bernardo Silva.

But that didn’t stop Villa winning 2-1 and securing fourth spot in the table. Elsewhere, Mohamed Salah and Andy Robertson said farewell to Liverpool which ended fifth and in the final Champions League spot after its 1-1 draw against Brentford.

Ten-man Chelsea lost 2-1 at Sunderland, meaning that newly appointed boss



Overjoyed: Arsenal players celebrate after finally laying their hands on the Premier League trophy. GETTY IMAGES

TOP OF THE CLASS

Goals: Erling Haaland (27) Assists: Bruno Fernandes (21) Clean sheets: David Raya (19)

Xabi Alonso will have no European football when he is at the helm next season. Sunderland and Bournemouth have qualified for the Europa League while Brighton will be in the UEFA Conference League. On the south coast, Manchester United captain Bruno Fernandes set a new outright record of 21 assists in a single Premier League season when he set up Patrick Dorgu’s goal in a 3-0 win at Brighton.

The results: Premier League:

Brighton 0 lost to Manchester United 3 (Dorgu 33, Mbeumo 44, Fernandes 48); Burnley 1 (Flemming 47) drew with Wolves 1 (Armstrong 5-pen); Crystal Palace 1 (Mateta 89) lost to Arsenal 2 (Jesus 42, Madueke 48), Fulham 2 (Diop 20, Cairney 80) bt Newcastle 0; Liverpool 1 (Jones 58) drew with Brentford 1 (Schade 64); Manchester City 1 (Semenyo 23) lost to Aston Villa 2 (Watkins 47, 61); Nottingham Forest 1 (Gibbs-White 34) drew with Bournemouth 1 (Tavernier 54); Sunderland 2 (Hume 25, Gusto 50-og) bt Chelsea 1 (Palmer 56); Tottenham 1 (Palhinha 43) bt Everton 0; West Ham 3 (Castellanos 67, Bowen 79, Wilson 90+4) bt Leeds 0. On Saturday: LaLiga: Valencia 3 (Guerra 66, Rioja 71, Rodriguez

90+7) bt Barcelona 1 (Lewandowski 61); Real Betis 2 (Ezzalzouli 5, Fornals 68) bt Levante 1 (Espí 45+1); Celta Vigo 1 (Moriba 51) bt Sevilla 0; Espanyol 1 (Fernandez 65) drew with Real Sociedad 1 (Oskarsson 28). Getafe 1 (Milla 59) bt Osasuna 0; Girona 1 (Martinez 48) drew with Elche 1 (Rodriguez 39); Real Mallorca 3 (Torre 42, Morlanes 83, Muriqi 88) bt Real Oviedo 0; Alaves 1 (Martinez 13) lost to Rayo Vallecano 2 (Camello 73, Nteka 90); Real Madrid 4 (Garcia 12, Bellingham 41, Mbappe 51, Diaz 88) bt Athletic Bilbao 2 (Guruzeta 45+1, Izeta 90+1). Serie A: Bologna 3 (Bernardeschi 25, Pobega 42, Zielinski 48-og) drew with Inter 3 (Dimarco 22, Esposito 64, Diouf 87). Lazio 2 (Dele-Bashiru 33, Pedro 35) bt Pisa 1 (Moreo 23).

INBRIEF



Gulveer sets 5,000m outdoor National record

Gulveer Singh set a new 5,000m outdoor National record while finishing second at the LA Track Fest, a World Athletics Continental Tour Silver level meet, in Los Angeles on Saturday. He timed 13m 03.93s to better his own mark of 13:11.82. The 27-year-old had clocked 12:59.77 at the Terrier DMR Challenge indoor competition in Boston last year and that is his overall National record in 5,000m. Eritrea’s Habtom Samuel produced a world-leading 12:57.23 for the gold.

Rohit Rajpal to be India’s Chef de Mission at CWG

Davis Cup captain Rohit Rajpal has been appointed India’s Chef de Mission for the upcoming Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, according to IOA sources. Ravi Bengani will be the Deputy Chef de Mission, while Vandana Rao and Rahul Swami will travel with the contingent as general team managers for the Games, scheduled from July 23 to August 2.



Aryaveer is boys’ U-19 Asian squash champion

Aryaveer Dewan became only the fourth Indian to emerge the Asian boys’ U-19 champion as he clinched the crown at the 33rd Asian Junior Individual Squash Championships in Panzhihua, China, on Sunday. Seeded 3/4, he beat South Korea’s Jonghyeok Lee, seeded 5/8, 11-2, 11-7, 11-9 in the final, as India returned with one gold, three silver and four bronze medals. Shiven Agarwal (boys’ U-17), Anika Dubey (girls’ U-17) and Amarya Bajaj (boys’ U-13) finished runner-up in their respective categories.

Other results: Boys: U-17: Nauman Khan (Pak) bt Shiven Agarwal 10-12, 11-7, 11-2, 11-5. **U-13:** Leung Ngo San (HKg) bt Amarya Bajaj 5-11, 8-11, 11-9, 12-10, 11-6. **Girls: U-17:** Harleein Tan (Mas) bt Anika Dubey 9-11, 11-4, 12-10, 11-4.



India qualifies for Junior Davis Cup (u-16) Finals

India qualified for the Junior Davis Cup (u-16) Finals after finishing fourth in the regional Asia-Oceania Final Qualifying in Shymkent, Kazakhstan, recently. The Rana Banerjee-coached team, comprising Tavish Pahwa, Hruthik Katakam and Ribhav Saroha, recorded wins over Indonesia (2-1), Malaysia (3-0) and China (3-0) in the round robin before beating Uzbekistan 2-0 in the quarterfinals. India lost the semifinals to Kazakhstan 0-2 and the third-place match to Japan by the same scoreline. The 16-team Finals will be held in Egypt later this year, and will feature Australia, Kazakhstan, Japan and India from the Asia-Oceania grouping.

Li Shifeng defends men’s title; Intanon triumphs

China’s Li Shifeng defended his Malaysia Masters men’s singles crown with a 21-16, 21-17 victory over Thailand’s Panitchaphon Teeraratsakul in Kuala Lumpur on Sunday. The women’s singles title went to Thailand’s Ratchanok Intanon, who was equally dominant in her 21-17, 21-15 victory over China’s Chen Yufei.

Other results: Doubles (finals): Women: Chen Fanshutian & Luo Xumin (Chn) bt Sayaka Hirota & Ayako Sakuramoto (Jpn) 21-16, 25-23. **Men:** Daniel Lundgaard & Mads Vestergaard (Den) bt Goh Sze Fei & Nur Izzusdin (Mas) 21-16, 21-17.

LIVE TELECAST

Roland Garros: Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LTV, 2.30 p.m.; Evening session, 12 a.m. (Tuesday)

ATHLETICS

Y.B. Sarangi
RANCHI

In a spectacular neck-and-neck contest, Dev Meena and training partner Kuldeep Kumar jointly rewrote the men’s pole vault National record with a mark of 5.45m in the Federation athletics meet at the Birsa Munda Stadium (Morabadi) on Sunday. Pushing each other hard, both showed good rhythm and cleared 5.45m. They raised the bar to 5.50m, but could not go past it. Meena claimed the gold ahead of Kuldeep, who had set the National mark of 5.41m earlier this month, on the basis of registering fewer total misses (Meena 8, Kuldeep 9).

The two earned their tickets for the Commonwealth Games.

Good fight

“We did our best today and gave each other a good fight. We will continue to keep up our fight in order to improve further,” said Meena. “We are still learning this technical sport and we will improve,” said Kuldeep.



Memorable: Meena came out on top in a neck-and-neck contest with training partner Kuldeep. RITU RAJ KONWAR

High jumper Sarvesh Kushare gave a good account of his focus to first register 2.22m and ensure his CWG journey. He improved it further to equal Tejaswin Shankar’s meet record (2.28m). However, his attempt to improve 1cm upon Tejaswin’s National record (2.29m) did not succeed. A consistent M. Sreesh-

ankar leaped to 8.08m in his third jump to qualify for the CWG. His last two attempts were fouls. Forty-year-old Olympian Sandeep Kumar emerged the men’s 10,000m race walk champion after 18-year-old winner Nitin Gupta was disqualified as per World Athletics Technical Rule 6.2, which prohibits assis-

Gukesh and Praggs battle for supremacy in Carlsen’s backyard

NORWAY CHESS

C. Shyam Sundar
OSLO

The rather quiet confines of Deichman Bjorvika, a public library here, will transform into a battlefield for the next two weeks as some of the best in the business will fight for top honours in Norway Chess from Monday.

The enigmatic Magnus Carlsen, an icon of world chess and Norwegian sport, will be the one to beat in the six-player Open event which also includes reigning World champion D. Gukesh and fellow Indian R. Praggnanandhaa. The women’s section features World title holder Ju Wenjun of China, India’s Koneru Humpy and Divya Deshmukh among others. It was at this tournament, albeit at a different venue (Stavanger), that Carlsen slammed the table in frustration after losing to Gukesh, his first defeat to



Intense battle looms: Carlsen will be keen to settle a score with Gukesh. FILE PHOTO

the Indian in the Classical format. The two will be at it again in the double round-robin event, and their duels promise to be intense. Gukesh and Carlsen apart, Praggnanandhaa, Vincent Keymer (Germany), Wesley So (USA) and Alireza Firouzja (France) give the Open line-up an elite look. In the women’s class, which carries the same prize money as the Open category, Ju will have to contend with fellow Chi-

nese Zhu Jiner, Humpy, Anna Muzychuk (Ukraine), Bibisara Assaubayeva of Kazakhstan and Divya for supremacy. According to tournament rules, should a classical game end in a draw, the players will go head-to-head in an Armageddon encounter to determine the winner. Kjell Madland, the tournament director, is expecting high-quality matches in the coming days. (The writer is in Oslo at the invitation of Norway Chess).

Pranati vaults to silver in World Challenge Cup

GYMNASTICS

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India’s Pranati Nayak clinched the women’s vault silver at the FIG World Challenge Cup 2026 in Tashkent. The 31-year-old Odisha gymnast secured an average score of 13.025 after registering 12.950 and 12.700 across her two vaults in the final on Saturday. Vietnam’s Thi Quynh Nhu Nguyen won the gold with 13.375. Uzbekistan’s Shakhinabonu Yusufova took bronze with 12.950. Protistha Samanta of India finished sixth with 12.850. In a social media post, Pranati said the past few



Pranati. x@SPORTS_ODISHA

months had been challenging but credited perseverance and faith for helping her bounce back. “The last couple of months have not been easy,” Pranathi, who trains at the Odisha AM/ NS India Gymnastics High Performance Centre in Bhubaneswar, wrote. “There were moments of doubt, setbacks and hard days, but I never stopped believing.”



In good form: Sreeshankar leapt 8.08m for the gold. RITU RAJ KONWAR



On top: Kushare gave a good account of his focus to first register 2.22m, and ensure his CWG journey. RITU RAJ KONWAR

tance to an athlete during an event, late on Saturday. Sandeep had filed a complaint after the race.

The results (finals):

Men: 1500m (CWG Q mark: 3:30.82): 1. Rahul Baloda (Raj) 3:40.06, 2. Sakir (Har) 3:40.83, 3.

Ajay Kumar Saroj (UP) 3:40.92; **110m hurdles (CWG Q mark 13.39):** 1. Tejas Shirse (Rel.) 13.50 (NMR, Old Tejas Shirse 13.61, 2023), 2. Krishik M. (Rel) 13.52, 2. Muhammed Lazan (Navy) 13.83; **Long jump (CWG Q mark: 8.05m):** 1. M. Sreeshankar (NCOE Thiruvananthapuram) 8.08m, 2. S. Lokesh (Rel) 7.94m, 3. Mohd. Atta Sazid (Har) 7.90m; **High jump (CWG Q mark 2.22m):** 1. Sarvesh Kushare (Mah) 2.28m (MR, Old 2.28m, Tejaswin Shankar, 2018), 2. Aadarsh Ram (TN) 2.22m, 3. Sudeep (Kar) 2.12m. **Discus (CWG Q mark 64.56m):** 1. Dharamraj Yadav (Army) 55.20m, 2. Bhartpreet Singh (Navy) 54.62m, 3. Oinam Alson Singh (NCOE Patiala) 53.52m; **Pole vault (CWG Q mark: 5.25m):** 1. Dev Meena (MP Academy) 5.45m (NR, Old 5.41m, Kuldeep Kumar, 2026), 2. Kuldeep Kumar (MP) 5.45m, 3. Reegan G. (TN) 5.15m. **Women: 100m hurdles (CWG Q mark 12.67):** 1. Nandhini K. (TN) 13.24, 2. Pragyan Prasanti Sahu (Od) 13.33, 3. Anjali C. (JSW) 13.35; **Hammer (CWG Q mark 66.80m):** 1. Manpreet Kaur (Pun) 59.08m, 2. Kulvinder Kaur (Rly) 57.76m, 3. Divya Shandilya (Od) 56.41m; **10,000m race walk (CWG Q mark 44:44.58):** 1. Ravina (Har) 44:29.66, 2. Reshma Patel (AIP) 44:57.94, 3. Munita Prajapati (UP) 45:23.92. **Saturday: Men: 10,000m race walk (CWG Q mark 39:06.28):** 1. Sandeep Kumar (Har) 39:51.95, 2. Servin (TN) 40:23.22, 3. Paramjeet Singh Bisht (Utk) 40:51.65.

Former Karnataka pacer Akshay passes away due to heart attack

CRICKET

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

Former Karnataka fast bowler S.L. Akshay passed away due to a heart attack here on Sunday. He was 39. Akshay, who was playing a KSCA third division match for Sapphire CC at SLS Kreedangana, left the field after bowling four overs. He was taken to a nearby hospital, where he was brought dead, officials stated. An effort bowler, Akshay played six First Class matches for Karnataka. He also featured in three List A and nine T20 games in an era when the State side boasted of a loaded pace trio in Vinay Kumar, Abhinanyu Mithun and S. Arvind. The Shivamogga-born Akshay made his senior Karnataka debut in a Vijay Hazare Trophy fixture against Hyderabad in Chennai in 2010. In his fi-



S.L. Akshay. FILE PHOTO: G.P. SAMPATH KUMAR

nal List A game three years later, he recorded career-best figures of four for 50 against Hyderabad. Akshay’s last Ranji Trophy appearance came against Haryana in Hubballi in 2012. He bowled 28 overs and picked up three wickets, even as Amit Mishra and Jayant Yadav put on a 392-

run eighth-wicket stand. Former Karnataka wicket-keeper-batter C.M. Gautam expressed shock at Akshay’s demise. “Akshay was a close friend. He was an amazing person. He was a pure soul with a good sense of humour,” Gautam said. “He was a very good fast bowler who always gave 100% on the field. Even recently, we played a KSCA Group II match for Bank of Baroda, and he bowled his heart out. He was the ultimate team man,” Gautam said. The Karnataka State Cricket Association (KSCA) paid tribute. “Akshay represented Karnataka with distinction at the First Class level, and even beyond his playing career, continued to serve the game with unwavering passion and dedication. “Karnataka cricket has lost not only a former player and coach but also a deeply valued member of its family,” a KSCA statement read.

Zuccaro wins the feature event

BENGALURU: P. Shroff trained Zuccaro (G. Vivek up), won the H.H. Jayachamaraja Wadiyar Cup (1,400m), the feature event of the races held here on Sunday (May 24). The winner is owned by Five Stars Shipping Co Pvt Ltd rep. by Mr. K.N. Dhunjibhoy, Mr. Z.K. Dhunjibhoy, Ms. Anosha Meyers, Mr. Vismi R. Patel, Mr. A.S. Narielwala, Mr. Eruch Adi Mody, Miss. Anita J. Captain, Mr. Dinshaw P. Adenwalla & Mrs. Jasmine D. Adenwalla. **THE RESULTS:** 1. BEAUTIFUL BABE PLATE (1,400M): STUD POKER (Antony) 1, Valor Queen (G. Vivek) 2, Shutterfly (Trevor) 3 and Bellucci (Arvind K) 4: 14-1/4, 3-3/4 and 5. Im, 24.06s. ₹19 (w), 12, 31 and 12 (p), SHP: 84, THP: 36, FP: 168, Q: 139, Trinella: 545/153, Exacta: 3,582/2,302. Favourite: Ibadath. Owners: Villoo Poonawalla Racing & Breeding Pvt Ltd, Mr. Atul Ishwar Das Chordia, M/s. DT Racing & Breeding LLP & Mr. S.R. Sanas. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar. 2. MINISTERIAL PLATE (1,100M): EVERYNNE (Trevor) 1, Garzian (A. Prakash) 2, Atman (Mukesh K) 3 and Portieux (Neeraj) 4. Not run: Nimbus Speed. Hd, 2-1/4 and 1-1/2. Im, 07.98s. ₹68 (w), 20, 35 and 10 (p), SHP: 118, THP: 42, FP: 1,099, Q: 657, Trinella: 2,017/413, Exacta: 9,197/7,883. Favourite: Atman. Owners: Mukteshwar Racing LLP & M/S. A.C. Bloodstock LLP. Trainer: S. Atcollahi. 3. PENDRAGON PLATE (DIV. II),

1,200M: ZEPHYRINE (Pavan) 1, Annabelle (Antony) 2, Blind Faith (A.S. Peter) 3 and The Make Sure (Ashhad Asbar) 4. Not run: Paradoxical. 2-1/4, Snk and 1-3/4. Im, 14.15s. ₹21 (w), 10, 10 and 17 (p), SHP: 25, THP: 37, FP: 60, Q: 28, Trinella: 236/134, Exacta: 409/111. Favourite: Zephyrine. Owner: M/s. Arun Alagappan Racing LLP. Trainer: Irfan Ghatala. 4. ALEKONA PLATE (1,600M): STAR OF INDIA (Aleemuddin) 1, Glorious Strides (Suraj) 2, Stalingrad (L.A. Rozario) 3 and Shahenshaah (Sai Kiran) 4. 2-1/4, Nose and 4-1/2. Im, 38.82s. ₹40 (w), 13, 10 and 19 (p), SHP: 35, THP: 34, FP: 141, Q: 28, Trinella: 277/227, Exacta: 1,315/1,216. Favourite: Glorious Strides. Owners: Ms. Ameeta Mehra, Mr. Chaduranga Kanthraj Urs, Mr. Anjan Kumar Rangaraj & Mr. P.J. Vazifdar. Trainer: James Mckeown. 5. VT. VELU MEMORIAL TROPHY (1,200M): LA MCQUEEN (Aleemuddin) 1, Fortis (Shreyas S) 2, Small Dreams (Mukesh K) 3 and Eternal Glory (G. Praveen) 4. 1-1/4, 3-1/4 and 1-1/2. Im, 14.16s. ₹37 (w), 13, 10 and 14 (p), SHP: 30, THP: 34, FP: 87, Q: 31, Trinella: 111/52, Exacta: 430/343. Favourite: Fortis. Owner: Mr. Ganesan Subramanian. Trainer: Arjun Mangalorkar. 6. H.H. JAYACHAMARAJA WADIYAR CUP (1,400M): ZUCCARO (G. Vivek) 1, Siege Courageous (Trevor) 2, Knotty Charmer (Antony) 3 and Galahad (Akshay K) 4. 2-1/4, Nk

and 1-1/2. Im, 24.11s. ₹28 (w), 15, 11 and 19 (p), SHP: 29, THP: 47, FP: 48, Q: 26, Trinella: 227/176, Exacta: 1,025/354. Favourite: Siege Courageous. Owners: Five Stars Shipping Co Pvt Ltd rep. by Mr. K.N. Dhunjibhoy, Mr. Z.K. Dhunjibhoy, Ms. Anosha Meyers, Mr. Vismi R. Patel, Mr. A.S. Narielwala, Mr. Eruch Adi Mody, Miss. Anita J. Captain, Mr. Dinshaw P. Adenwalla & Mrs. Jasmine D. Adenwalla. Trainer: P. Shroff. 7. COMMONWEALTH DAY PLATE (1,200M): MYSTIKOS (Trevor) 1, Breeze Bluster (Antony) 2, Eboste (Aleemuddin) 3 and Southern Force (Akshay K) 4. Not run: Peridot. 1-3/4, 1-1/2 and 1. Im, 14.32s. ₹19 (w), 10, 15 and 26 (p), SHP: 42, THP: 46, FP: 51, Q: 40, Trinella: 217/132, Exacta: 242/197. Favourite: Mystikos. Owner: Mrs. Sreya Bose. Trainer: K. Purshotham. 8. PENDRAGON PLATE (DIV. I), 1,200M: GLORIOUSNESS (Suraj) 1, Jade Mountain (Trevor) 2, Scent Of Rain (Sandesh) 3 and Mnemosyne (Akshay K) 4. 2-1/4, 2-1/2 and 1. Im, 13.49s. ₹26 (w), 14, 10 and 12 (p), SHP: 30, THP: 41, FP: 109, Q: 38, Trinella: 84/36, Exacta: 364/218. Favourite: Scent Of Rain. Owners: Mr. Raghu S. Mr. S. Narreddu, Mr. Anil Saraf & M/s. Brahmashta Racing LLP. Trainer: S. Narreddu. Jackpot: ₹8,499. Runner-up: 634; Mini Jackpot: 1,154; Treble (i): 786; (ii): 238.

Kane hat-trick powers Bayern to German Cup triumph

Associated Press
BERLIN

Harry Kane cut through the smoke of the German Cup final with a hat-trick for Bayern Munich to beat defending champion Stuttgart 3-0 and complete another domestic double. Kane’s goals in the second half set off fireworks among the Bayern fans who had joined their Stuttgart rivals in protesting against the German soccer federation (DFB) for a planned increase in security measures. **The result:** Bayern Munich 3 (Kane 54, 79, 90+1) bt Stuttgart 0.

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Sanil Raj Johnson

Some of the most significant discoveries in human history began with a simple question. The ability to ask thoughtful questions has always been central to intellectual growth, and classrooms that promote questioning often become spaces where genuine learning occurs. From the era of the Greek philosopher Socrates to today's research settings, questioning has remained a key method of inquiry.

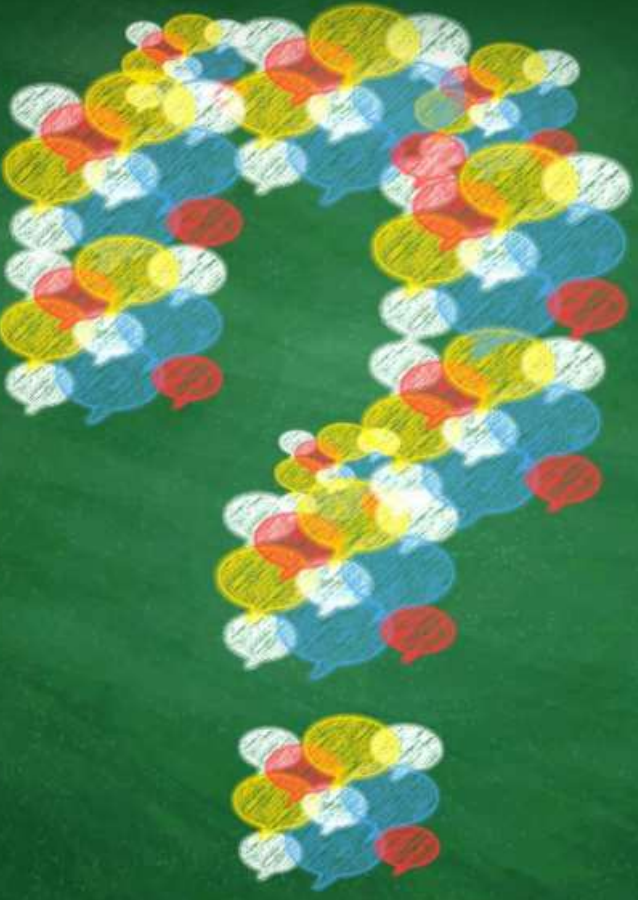
Beyond testing

In contemporary classrooms, however, questioning often happens only after a lesson ends. Teachers typically ask a few predictable questions just to check if students have memorised the material. At a time when classrooms focus heavily on exams, documentation, and covering the syllabus, the art of questioning can revive curiosity and increase intellectual engagement.

Thoughtfully crafted questions activate a wide range of intellectual abilities and teach students to explore ideas from various perspectives and develop the skill to draw meaningful conclusions. Take, for example, a lesson on World War I. Instead of presenting the event as a collection of dates and facts, the teacher can guide the students through a sequence of questions. The first question might be: *Who were the two factions involved?* This can be followed by further inquiries: *How did the war begin? What were the political*

Question everything

The importance of the art of questioning in the classroom



and economic causes behind it? What major events shaped its course? How did the conflict end, and what consequences did it have for the world?

As students attempt to answer these, they gradually construct the historical narrative themselves and understand the relationship among causes, events, and outcomes. Instead of memorising isolated facts, students begin to perceive history as a dynamic process shaped by interconnected factors.

The power of questioning extends across all academic disciplines. In Literature classrooms, for example, questions can guide students from basic comprehension to deeper interpretation. When introducing a poem, the teacher may begin with simple questions about the author and the title, and gradually, the discussion can move towards analytical inquiry. *What themes emerge from the text? What figures of speech are used? What message does the poet attempt to convey?* Such questions encourage students to engage in discussion and enable them to participate actively in the process of interpretation.

In Science education, questioning plays a crucial role in sparking curiosity about the natural world. The history of Science shows how discoveries often start with simple questions. An apple falling from a tree led Isaac Newton to reportedly ask why the apple fell down. This curiosity eventually helped develop the law of gravitation.

In an elementary biology class, instead of merely describing the parts of a

plant, a teacher might start by asking what role leaves play. As students move to higher levels, these questions can lead to more in-depth discussions.

Role in research

At advanced levels, questioning becomes the foundation of scholarly research. A doctoral thesis, for instance, is built upon carefully framed research questions. Scholars must define a thesis argument, formulate a hypothesis, justify the choice of topic, and explain the structure of their study. Questions regarding methodology, findings, and the scope for further investigation guide the research process. Thus, research itself can be understood as the systematic pursuit of answers to significant questions.

Yet, the most meaningful questions often come from the learner's own curiosity rather than those imposed from outside. They are not limited to textbook exercises or confined to the end of a lesson. Instead, they arise spontaneously whenever learners encounter something puzzling or intriguing. The teacher's role is not just to provide answers but to create an environment where questioning feels natural and ongoing. Reclaiming the art and skill of questioning can be one of the most effective ways to promote deeper learning and sustained intellectual engagement.

The writer is a Professor of English and Dean of Student Affairs, Sahridaya College of Advanced Studies (Autonomous), Thrissur, Kerala. Email: saniljohn03@gmail.com

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Courtesy: buddy4study.com

HCL Jigsaw

HCL's student innovation platform HCL Jigsaw invites registrations for its seventh edition.

With a Rs 12 lakh prize pool, this year's competition moves from traditional quiz-based models to teams that will work towards identifying real-world problems, building solutions, developing prototypes, and pitching their ideas at a national finale.

The four themes for this edition are: AI and Digital Futures; Climate and

Sustainability; Medical Innovation; Healthcare accessibility, smart diagnostics, wellness technologies, and assistive innovation; Robotics and Automation.

The competition has five stages with the national finale to be held on November 22, 2026.

Eligibility: Students from Classes 6 to 9 from any board or school across India. Registrations must be submitted through their respective schools only.

Deadline: July 31. For more details and to register, visit www.hcljigsaw.com



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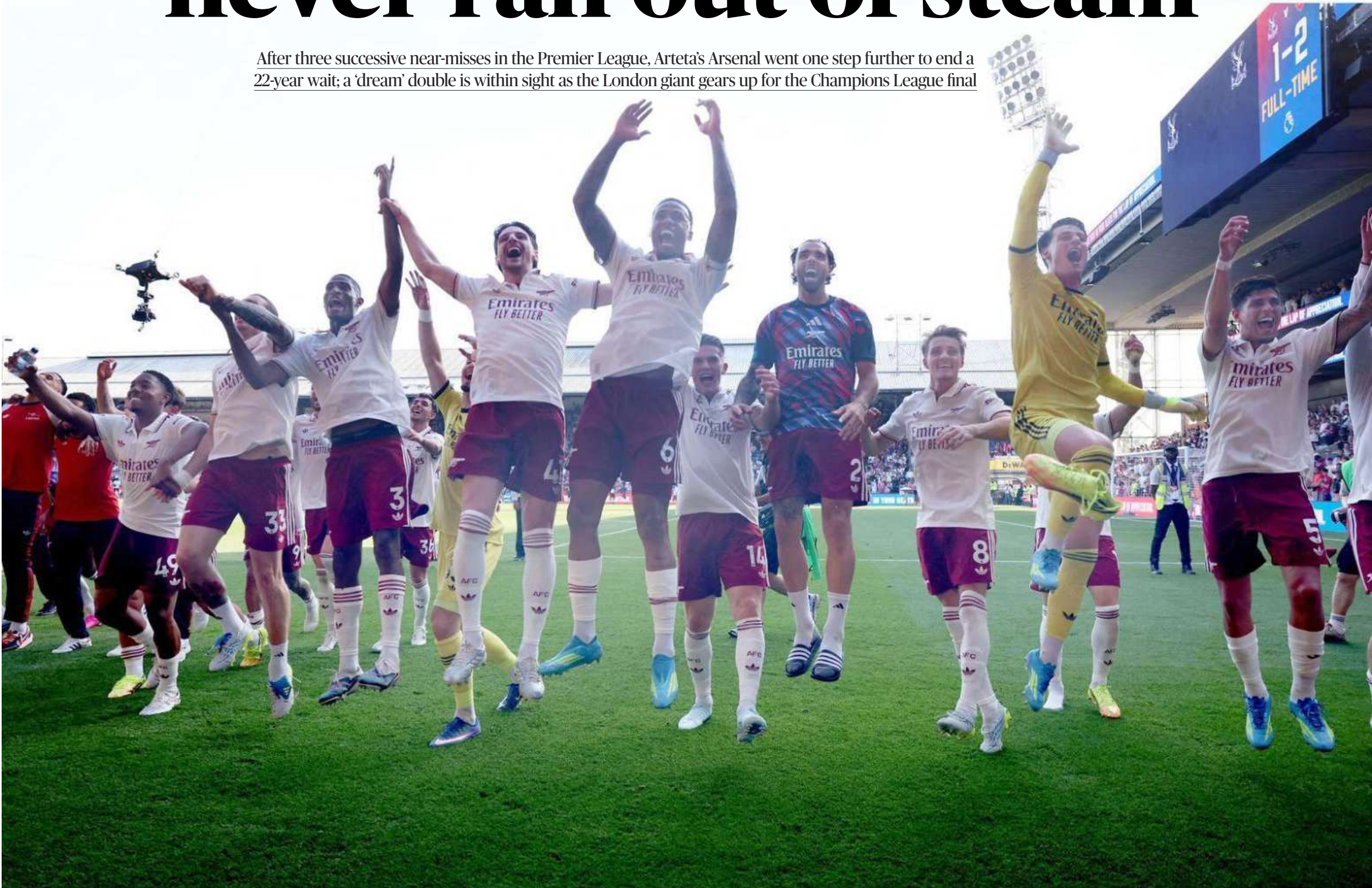
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A winning machine that never ran out of steam

After three successive near-misses in the Premier League, Arteta's Arsenal went one step further to end a 22-year wait; a 'dream' double is within sight as the London giant gears up for the Champions League final



REUTERS

Natalia Hannah Rice

In a February evening at the Tottenham Hotspur Stadium, Mikel Arteta stood on the touchline with clenched fists as Arsenal dismantled north London rival Tottenham Hotspur 4-1.

The result was one of the clearest indicators of Arsenal's evolution this season. The manager's reaction reflected the composure and confidence of a side that had steadily developed into a genuine title contender.

Scoring four goals in a derby away from home, Arsenal combined attacking precision with control, underlining the tactical maturity and consistency that carried it to its first Premier League (PL) title in over two decades.

The victory over Tottenham came to symbolise the authority with which Arsenal approached a season that had been years in the making under Arteta.

By then, Arsenal had developed into a team defined by tactical control, defensive consistency and attacking depth, qualities that sustained its challenge through the closing weeks of the PL campaign.

Arteta became the first manager to secure the PL crown with a club he had represented as a player and the first to win it for Arsenal since Wenger

For Arsenal, it marked the end of a 22-year wait for the Premier League crown, and the trophy was a reward for Arteta's rebuilding project.

After three successive runner-up finishes, the London club finally reclaimed the title with a campaign built on balance

rather than dependence on a single player.

Arteta became the first manager to secure the PL crown with a club he had represented as a player. He is the first to win it for the Gunners since Arsene Wenger, who guided Arsenal's 'Invincibles' all the way in 2004.

The weight of history

To understand what this title means, one has to understand what came before it. Three consecutive second-place finishes. Three years of watching the trophy go elsewhere. In 2022-23, City overtook it in the final weeks.

The following season, Guardiola's side pipped it by a gut-wrenching two points. Last year, it was Liverpool which denied the London-based club.

Each near-miss left its scar, and each scar was absorbed, processed, and turned

into fuel for success.

Rather than abandoning his methods, Arteta continued to refine the squad and improve its tactical balance. The current contingent has combined defensive organisation with attacking depth, evolving into a team capable of controlling matches as comfortably as it created chances.

Arsenal led the league for more than 200 days. When City briefly moved ahead on goal difference late in the season, Arteta's side responded emphatically, winning four successive matches without conceding and reclaiming control of the title race.

The response reflected a squad hardened by repeated near-misses and one that was fully equipped to meet the demands.

When doubt came calling

The final weeks of the league season were not without tension. A 1-2 home defeat to Bournemouth on April 11. A 1-2 loss at the Etihad a week later; it trimmed the lead and invited familiar narratives back in.

For a brief and uncomfortable period, it felt recognisably, painfully, like seasons past. Arsenal's answer was wins over Newcastle United, Fulham, West Ham United, Burnley, each dispatched with economy of effort and with clarity of purpose. A title reclaimed, methodically and without drama, from the precipice of doubt.

On May 19, they did not even need to take the field. Bournemouth, the very side that had beaten it at the Emirates six weeks prior, held City. What Arsenal had fought for across nine months of sustained, disciplined, collective endeavour was now formally confirmed. The celebrations that followed outside the Emirates had been 22 years in the waiting.

The team that delivered

Behind the PL title lies not the brilliance of one man but the quiet, accumulated excellence of many. It is precisely that collectivity which lends the triumph its peculiar beauty.

Viktor Gyokeres, recruited from Sporting CP last summer, has led Arsenal's attack with authority. He is the club's leading scorer this season – 21 goals across all competitions, a distinction earned through persistence as much as talent.

Around him, Bukayo Saka has remained the relentless, indispensable force he has been for several seasons, a player who simply does not allow the

Rather than abandoning his methods, Arteta continued to refine the squad and improve its tactical balance. The team has combined defensive organisation with attacking depth

game to pass by. Eberechi Eze has brought unpredictability – a top-corner volley on the turn in the Champions League bout against Bayer Leverkusen, a moment of improvised genius.

Leandro Trossard, Declan Rice, Martin Zubimendi, and Mikel Merino scored with such regularity, no single absence unsettled the architecture of the side.

The assists tell an equally compelling story of shared responsibility. Trossard and Martin Odegaard led the way with six Premier League assists, their creative instincts operating on different frequencies yet producing identical returns. Rice, Saka, and Jurrien Timber each contributed five.

It created an attacking structure with multiple points of entry and no discernible weakness. Opponents who prepared for Saka encountered Eze. Those who planned for Gyokeres found Trossard threading quietly through the lines.

At the back, Gabriel and William Saliba have fashioned a defensive partnership that now ranks among Europe's finest. David Raya won the Premier League Golden Glove for the third consecutive season, keeping 19 clean sheets, a defensive record that underpins everything Arteta has built.

And then there is Max Dowman, at just 16 years old, became the youngest goalscorer in Premier League history earlier this season.

He also earned the distinction of being the youngest player ever to win the PL title. At 16 years and 144 days, he has surpassed Phil Foden's record.

A European statement

While the league title has commanded the broader narrative, Arsenal's Champions League campaign runs it close for sheer quality. It merits careful examination, for it reveals dimensions of this side that domestic results alone cannot fully illuminate.

In November, Bayern Munich arrived at the Emirates. It left having conceded three. It was neither fortune nor a smash-and-grab. It was controlled, methodical, and at times imperious, a performance that communicated, with

quiet authority, that Arsenal had come to Europe not merely to participate but to contend.

The away fixtures that followed carried the same conviction: three goals at Club Brugge in December was followed by three more against Inter Milan in January, the latter stirring comparisons to the great continental nights the Gunners have known only too rarely.

The knockout rounds became a study in temperament as much as technique. The round-of-16 tie against Leverkusen witnessed an Eze volley of such ferocity and precision that it will be replayed for years; the 2-0 home win completed the job.

Against Sporting in the quarterfinals, Kai Havertz's goal proved sufficient in Lisbon. The goalless second leg was not beautiful, but it was purposeful; exactly the manner in which great sides distinguish themselves from merely good ones.

The semifinal paired Arsenal with Diego Simeone's Atletico Madrid, a side built on structure and hard lines, the yardstick against which all European challengers are tested. A tense 1-1 draw in the Spanish capital.

Then a 1-0 victory at a thunderous Emirates, settled by the tie's only moment of decisive quality courtesy Saka. Arsenal had passed, unbeaten, every examination Europe had put before it.

In Budapest on May 30, it faces defending champion Paris Saint-Germain in the final – Arsenal's second appearance in the competition's showpiece, 20 years on from the heartbreak at the hands of Barcelona in Paris. And a chance to claim the one honour missing in its 139-year history.

Etched in red and white

Arteta has written his name permanently into Arsenal's history. He inherited a club that had plainly lost its way, rebuilt it patiently, methodically and without compromise. And he delivered.

Arsenal claimed its 14th English top-flight championship, sitting behind only Liverpool and Manchester United (20 each).

The Crystal Palace fixture on Sunday was, in every meaningful sense, a joyful formality. Beyond it lies Budapest and the possibility of a double that would render this the finest season in the club's 140-year history.

The promised land is within reach and Arteta's Arsenal, it would appear, is only just getting started.

THE GIST

▼ When City briefly moved ahead on goal difference late in the Premier League season, Arteta's side responded emphatically, winning four consecutive matches without conceding

▼ Behind the PL title lies not the brilliance of one man but the excellence of many

▼ It was Arsenal's 14th English top-flight championship as it sat behind only Liverpool and Manchester United (20 each)

Long-awaited anti-COVID drug is also a milestone against future viruses

Betacoronaviruses have now caused three major outbreaks in recent memory; drugs like Ensitrelvir provide scientists with a valuable starting point against this entire sub-family of viruses, possibly allowing humankind to respond more quickly when the next virus will inevitably emerge

Arun Panchapakesan

The recent success of Ensitrelvir at preventing COVID-19 is a milestone in a drug quest that began with a singular development at the start of the pandemic. In January 2020, the full-length genome sequence of a strain of the SARS-CoV-2 virus was posted on an online discussion forum for virologists. The sequence revealed that SARS-CoV-2, like its relative SARS-CoV-1, keeps most of its proteins as one long chain. The individual proteins are then cut from this chain and released by enzymes called proteases.

Inconvenient guests

SARS-CoV-2 has two proteases called the main protease (M^{pro}), which does most of the cutting, and the Papain-like protease (PL^{pro}) which cuts the three sites at one end of the chain that the M^{pro} does not process. Almost immediately after the genome sequence was published, scientists knew that both these proteases were attractive drug targets. Viruses are made of the same material as their host cells. The viral membrane is derived from the host's cell-membranes, and the viral proteins are made by the host cell itself. This makes antiviral drug development more challenging than developing drugs against, say, bacteria. Most other pathogens are living cells with several features that humans do not have. For instance, bacteria have a rigid cell wall. Antibiotics can be made that block the synthesis of this cell wall, and those antibiotics will affect only the bacteria without affecting humans much. Also, that antibiotic will work against most classes of bacteria because most of them have a cell wall. Viruses, however, do not offer such conveniences. Since they rely heavily on the host cell's machinery, drugs that attack the virus can also risk damaging healthy cells. As a result, there is no broad-spectrum antiviral drug. Instead, scientists usually need to design drugs specifically for a particular virus, or if they are lucky, for a group of closely related viruses that share similar proteins. A drug shelved This is why viral proteins that are essential for the virus while being significantly different from human proteins are extremely valuable drug targets. Both SARS-CoV-2 proteases fit this description perfectly. The virus cannot replicate without them and human cells do not have identical versions of these enzymes. Among them, M^{pro} was the first choice for most researchers.



A person diagnosed with COVID-19 being shifted to a ward at King George Hospital, Visakhapatnam on January 22, 2022. K.R. DEEPAK

When scientists sequenced the SARS-CoV-2 genome, those at Pfizer realised its M^{pro} protease was very similar to that of SARS-CoV-1. It so happened that a few years ago, they had developed an intravenous drug called PF-00835231 targeting the M^{pro} of SARS-CoV-1. However, when the virus vanished in early 2004, they shelved the compound thinking they would not need it again. In 2020, knowing that the two M^{pro} proteins are similar, they set out to re-engineer PF-00835231 because an intravenous drug would be useless at controlling a pandemic the size of COVID-19, where most people would not get admitted to a hospital. After a few months, they developed Nirmatrelvir. By the time they finished clinical trials, it was already late 2021. Different approach However, while Nirmatrelvir was very effective as an oral drug, it had major problems. First, it was metabolised very quickly by the liver. To keep it in the bloodstream for longer, scientists had to add a second drug, Ritonavir, to the regimen to slow down the liver's ability to metabolise Nirmatrelvir. The problem? Ritonavir had dangerous interactions with common heart and blood pressure medications. And then there was the added side effect of a bitter aftertaste. Around the same time that Pfizer was engineering Nirmatrelvir, a Japanese

pharmaceutical company named Shionogi took a different approach to targeting M^{pro}. Instead of making and testing millions of potential drug candidates, they decided in the interest of time that they would use computational chemistry to 'virtually' screen compounds. Using the structure of the M^{pro} protease, they simulated thousands of molecules that would bind the protease and inactivate it. This approach quickly identified a promising molecule that they could then test further. Then they partnered with the International Institute for Zoonosis Control at Hokkaido University for testing. With a few tweaks, they came up with a molecule that stayed in the blood for a long time without the need for additional drugs and did not have the bitter after-taste. They called this molecule Ensitrelvir. SCORPIO-PEP trial Ensitrelvir was granted emergency approval in Japan for use in November 2022 to treat mild-to-moderate COVID-19. In early 2024, it was granted full authorisation for regular use. Now, a new paper in the *New England Journal of Medicine* has reported that it can also be used for postexposure prophylaxis – to prevent infection after exposure to the virus. The international study, called the SCORPIO-PEP trial, involved 2,387

participants, all of whom were exposed to an infected household member. They were assigned to a test or a placebo group at random. Participants in the test group received Ensitrelvir and the control group received the placebo. The results revealed that Ensitrelvir lowered the incidence of symptomatic COVID-19 from 9% in the control group to 2.9% in the group that took the drug – a drop of 67%. The trial scientists showed that irrespective of whether symptoms developed, the presence of SARS-CoV-2 in the contacts was reduced from 21.5% to 14%. Importantly, the drug maintained a good safety profile in the study. The authors concluded that giving Ensitrelvir to contacts within 72 hours of a primary patient showing symptoms could effectively prevent COVID-19. SARS-CoV-2 today does not pose the threat it once did but the importance of Ensitrelvir extends well beyond COVID-19. Betacoronaviruses have now caused three major outbreaks in just over two decades: SARS-CoV-1, MERS-CoV, and SARS-CoV-2. Drugs like Ensitrelvir provide scientists with a valuable starting point against this entire sub-family of viruses, possibly allowing humankind to respond more quickly when the next virus will inevitably emerge. (Arun Panchapakesan is an assistant professor at the Y.R. Gaitonde Centre for AIDS Research and Education, Chennai. arun.panchapakesan@gmail.com)

THE GIST

▼ Ensitrelvir was granted emergency approval in Japan for use in November 2022 to treat mild-to-moderate COVID-19. In early 2024, it was granted full authorisation for regular use

▼ A new paper in the *New England Journal of Medicine* has reported that it can also be used for postexposure prophylaxis – to prevent infection after exposure to the virus

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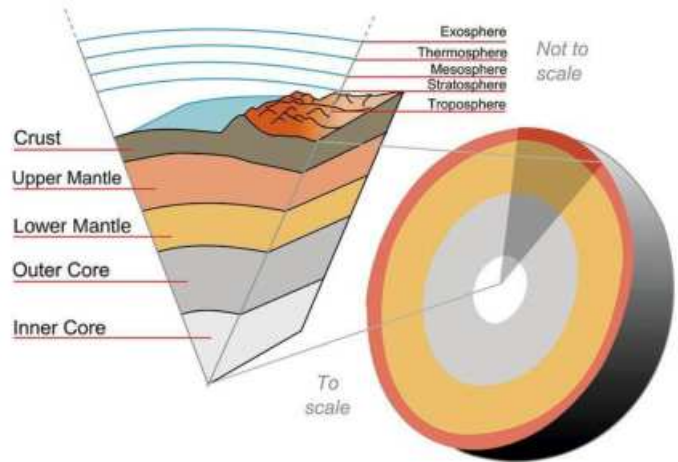
BIG SHOT



Astronauts for the Shenzhou 23 crewed mission, from left: Hong Kong's Lai Ka-ying (identified by Chinese authorities as Li Jiaying) and China's Zhu Yangzhu and Zhang Zhiyuan wave as they attend a seeing-off ceremony for their crewed space mission at the Jiuquan Satellite Launch Centre in northwestern China on Sunday. AP

WHAT IS IT?

Outer core: unafraid of drama



An infographic depicting the earth's geophysical layers. SURACHIT (CC BY-SA)

Vasudevan Mukunth

The earth's outer core is a voluminous liquid layer that lies around 2,800 km beneath the surface. This hot, churning sea is filled with molten iron and nickel. As the outer core moves constantly, it acts like a large generator, creating the planet's magnetic field, which shields the earth from harmful solar radiation. Researchers from the University of Edinburgh and the British Geological Survey have reported that around 2010, the liquid iron in the outer core below the equatorial Pacific Ocean changed direction from a slow westward crawl to a more rapid eastward surge. They found this after mapping 27 years of iron movement in the outer core using data from ground stations and four European satellites. They identified two important patterns in the flow. The main pattern accounted for 95% of the movement: it consisted of a

steady flow westwards — which also explains why the earth's magnetic field has historically drifted west. The second pattern revealed the dramatic shift in 2010. The researchers also found that this shift began to weaken around 2020. The researchers were able to link the 2010 reversal to seismic and geodetic shifts in the earth's solid inner core. According to their model, the flow is also roughly 10% lopsided between the northern and the southern hemispheres. These details could explain sudden 'jerks' in magnetic field readings and suggest that deep-earth liquids can change direction much faster than the traditional theory predicts.



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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Acres of barren land in Ladakh to be reclaimed

800 Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Sunday launched an restoration project to reclaim nearly 800 acres of barren land and transform it into productive ecosystem through innovative freshwater recharge techniques. PTI

Percentage increase in post-COVID hip damage surgeries

40 in per cent. A worrying post-pandemic orthopaedic trend has emerged across India, with doctors reporting a significant rise in cases of hip arthritis and avascular necrosis (AVN), particularly among younger and middle-aged adults. PTI

Number of homestay registrations cancelled by Dehradun

103 Dehradun district administration has cancelled registrations of 103 homestays on Sunday following extensive inspections, revealing violations of safety norms and operational guidelines, officials said. PTI

Persons sentenced to life imprisonment in Nabarangpur clash

19 Nineteen people were sentenced to life imprisonment by a court in Odisha in a 2016 clash between two groups that left three persons dead. The incident happened on July 16, 2016 following a dispute over the cultivation of government land. PTI

Persons killed in mine blast at the Liushenyu shaft in China

82 Rescuers in northern China searched on Sunday for two people still missing after a gas explosion killed 82 in a mine that authorities said was beset by serious safety violations. PTI
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What is China’s Hainan FTP initiative?

How has Hainan's free trade port changed tariffs and trade rules? Why is the FTP attracting new enterprises? What benefits are businesses gaining? How are the duty-free system and visa-free policy boosting tourism and consumption? What strategic role does FTP play in China's comparison with Hong Kong?

EXPLAINER

Vighnesh P. Venkitesh

The story so far:

Hainan, China's southernmost province and a tropical island in the South China Sea, has come to the forefront of the country's modern-era opening-up efforts with the beginning of its free trade port (FTP) and customs closure in December. Envisioned as a 'landmark leap' into economic ease, China is trying to set up a business hub in the island province aimed at attracting global and local customers with the appeal of zero tariffs, low personal taxes, and simplified flow of commuters and data.

What is the free trade port initiative? The plan for the FTP in Hainan was first unveiled on June 1, 2020. The FTP was officially launched on December 18, 2025, with island-wide special customs operations implementing the policy of "freer access at the first line, regulated access at the second line, and free flow within the island". Under the initiative, tariff barriers on trade were removed from the island with the closure of ordinary customs operations, enabling easier imports. While the island remains an integral part of China, it has now become a neutral zone for international trade, with regular customs procedures and tariffs applying only to goods entering the Chinese mainland from the island. Visa-free entry for people from 86 countries is also expected to boost tourism.

Hainan will be a "new frontier of opening up, hub for regional cooperation and engine for economic globalisation," said Wang Bin, spokesperson for the Chinese Communist Party's Hainan Committee, ahead of the official opening of the FTP. He added that the FTP would help save 860 million RMB in tariffs annually while creating investment opportunities for Chinese enterprises in the Global South.



The International Yacht Centre at Sanya Central Business District, a key tourist and industrial hub in Hainan. VIGHNESH P. VENKITESH

How will the initiative help China's trade?

The island-wide special customs operation is seen as an opportunity to "deepen reforms in key sectors, steadily advance high-quality development, improve risk prevention, and build the FTP into a leading gateway for China's opening-up in the new era," He Lifeng, Chinese Vice-Premier, said at the launch of the FTP on December 18.

Since the launch, the number of tariff-free product categories has expanded from around 1,900 to 6,600, while the share of goods eligible for zero tariffs has risen from 21% to 74%. *Global Times* reported that 3,265 foreign-invested enterprises registered in the FTP between December 18 and December 31, while over 30,000 foreign trade registration enterprises were added in 2025.

According to Haikou Customs, goods worth around 753 million yuan (about \$107 million) were imported into Hainan in the first few months after the FTP's opening. The value of processed and value-added goods brought into the mainland during the same period stood at around 85.9 million yuan.

How are businesses benefiting?

The establishment of the FTP has drawn numerous industries to the island. The MI

Coffee Dream Factory in Wanning is one such enterprise benefiting from the initiative. "We import coffee beans for RMB 1,100 per kilo from Panama, which cost RMB 1,700 per kilo on the mainland," said Tong Shuo, director of MI.

Hainan Ausca International Oils and Grains Co., Ltd., established with a total investment of 3.5 billion RMB, is among the first enterprises operating within the FTP. It piloted the import tariff exemption policy to produce goods with at least 30% added value after processing. The group started construction in September 2020, soon after the FTP plan was unveiled, and opened its first production line in April 2021. It now has a production line of 2 million tonnes per year.

How does the initiative encourage consumers?

The FTP has also opened Hainan to individual consumers.

Sanya, the province's main tourist hub, houses the China Duty Free centre, with a collection of global and local brands competing for customers. The CDF offers a shopping experience for both international tourists and mainland residents, provided they present a return ticket at entry. Local residents, however, face a shopping cap of 1,00,000 RMB per person per year and must travel out of the

province once a year.

"The FTP is expected to bring benefits with an increase in overseas visitors, which will boost spending and help the local economy," said Bai Xue, deputy general manager at Sanya CDF. "The visa-free policy will help us provide a window to showcase Chinese culture to the world, while introducing local brands and shifting focus from the world to China," she added.

The *Global Times* reported that offshore duty-free shopping in Hainan exceeded 2 billion RMB since the FTP's opening, with more than 3,00,000 shoppers. Haikou and Sanya, the two major cities of the province, have seen the fastest growth in inbound flight ticket bookings.

What does China seek to gain with Hainan?

While Hainan is on its way to further China's strategy of economic opening up, there are multiple factors affecting its success. Unlike Hong Kong – one of the world's leading financial hubs, being a special administrative region under the Chinese government, with its own legal system, currency, and independent membership in international trade organisations – Hainan is China in all perspectives and domain.

With a customs-free, tariff-free, region outside the mainland that follows all other legal and constitutional provisions, China has made both a partner and competitor to Hong Kong in Hainan. China now has an open economic and tourist zone at the northern end of the much-contested South China Sea, with fresh and vast economic opportunities compared to congested Hong Kong.

The geopolitical and economic implications of Hainan, and its output to China, which seeks to attain "socialist modernisation" in the coming decade, will be unveiled in time.

For now, the Hainan experiment is attracting eyes and its baby strides are firm. *(The writer was in China at the invitation of the China Public Diplomacy association)*

THE GIST

▼ Hainan has launched its free trade port (FTP) with island-wide "customs closure," enabling "freer access at the first line, regulated access at the second line, and free flow within the island," along with zero tariffs, lower taxes and simplified movement of trade, people and data.

▼ The FTP is attracting foreign-invested enterprises and boosting trade, tourism and consumption through expanded tariff-free products, duty-free shopping, visa-free entry for 86 countries, and growing investment and trade volumes since its launch.

When does purposeful writing evolve in children?

At what age should a child start writing? Can early writing become a burden for children?

M. Emmanuel Bhaskar

The story so far:

Most of us have seen a two-year-old child hold a crayon and scribble. In most cases, school educators see that a kindergarten child can grip a pencil and therefore encourage them to write. But we need to assess if the child writes without pain and fatigue. Most importantly, does the child enjoy writing at this age?

In what stages does purposeful writing evolve?

At 1-2 years, the palmar grasp is established, and the child uses the entire arm movement to scribble. At 2-3 years, the child can rotate the forearm. The child can now hold the pencil with fingers, but the shoulder still dominates when writing. Between 3 and 4 years, the four-finger grasp is established. The child uses all fingers except the little finger and can draw a fairly straight line, an incomplete circle, and may colour within

a picture outline.

At 4-5 years, the grasp improves and becomes a three-finger grip. The pencil is held between the thumb and index finger, while the middle finger supports it from below. The ring and little fingers rest on the writing paper. However, the movement depends on the wrist since the finger muscles are weak. At this age, a child can write, but doing so for a long period will result in pain in the hand, elbow, or shoulder.

The middle finger may hurt since it supports the pencil. The thumb or index finger can hurt due to the pressure of holding the pencil firmly for a long time. The elbow may hurt because of constant bending and pressure on the writing surface. The shoulder may be painful because the muscles around it must continuously contract to keep the elbow in position.

What are the mechanics of writing?

Writing requires coordination of many nerves, muscles, and joints. We can start with shoulder stability. You will notice

that your shoulder barely moves while writing.

The elbow moves only sideways, helping the hand move across the page. This movement often happens in the air and sometimes with support from the table or another surface. The wrist, too, holds its position and does not bend sideways as the hand moves from left to right. Only the thumb and index finger actively move. The other fingers move along without any movement in and of themselves. This is just what happens in the upper limb.

Writing is controlled by the brain. Here enters the hand-eye coordination, the child's memory of the shape of letters, the sequence of letters, and, more importantly, attention and patience.

What is the difference between circle and alphabet drawing?

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) in the U.S. lists that a three-year-old "draws a circle when you show the child how to do it". When drawing a circle, the shoulder rotates

freely, so shoulder stability is less important. The wrist and the finger grip move as a whole when drawing a circle. In other words, the child holds the crayon or a pencil between the thumb and index finger or even with the whole palm and rotates the shoulder with decent accuracy to complete the circle.

Writing requires precise motor planning. When a child switches between complex letters, direction changes along with the curve, size of deflections, stopping and turning, spacing and many more.

What should be the norm?

A kindergarten child can use a crayon to colour designs with large spaces. A pencil grip should be avoided at this age. In upper kindergarten, a child may try to write alphabets like A, C, E, F, H, I, K, L, M, N, O, T, V, W, X, Y and Z which have straight lines or circles with no complex curves as in B, D, G, J, P, Q, R, S and U.

By the age of five, the child can be assessed for a proper hand grip, and if found capable, more complex writing can be attempted. We should remember that each child may have variations in their ability to do all that is required for writing. This is where parents' and teachers' efforts in the kindergarten and pre-school phase at home determine if the child starts to love writing or considers it a burden.

(M. Emmanuel Bhaskar, MD, is Professor of Medicine, Sri Ramachandra Medical College and Research Institute, Chennai)

THE GIST

▼ Writing in young children develops in stages from scribbling with whole-arm movement to controlled finger movement, and early pencil grip or long writing can cause pain in the hand, elbow, or shoulder due to muscle strain and poor coordination.

▼ Purposeful writing requires coordination of shoulder stability, wrist control, finger movement, and brain functions like memory and attention, so it should be introduced gradually based on the child's age and ability.

